



தாயுமானவர்... அனைவர் வாழ்விலும் சிறந்த மாற்றம்! ஸ்டாலின் அரசு தந்த முன்னேற்றம்!!

அன்புக்கரங்கள் திட்டம்

பெற்றோரை இழந்த
10,637 குழந்தைகள்
கல்வியைத் தொடர மாதம் ரூ.2000

தாயுமானவர் திட்டம்

27.41 இலட்சம் மாற்றுத்திறனாளிகள்
& முதியோர் இல்லங்களுக்கே சென்று
ரேஷன் பொருள்கள் வழங்கல்

மாற்றுத்திறனாளிகள்

பராமரிப்புத் தொகை
ரூ. 2,000 ஆக உயர்வு
2.59 இலட்சம்
மாற்றுத்திறனாளிகள் பயன்

கலைஞர் கைவினைத் திட்டம்

தமிழ்நாட்டின் பல்வேறு கைவினைக்
கலைஞர்கள் 23,879 பேருக்கு
ரூ. 405 கோடி கடனுதவி
ரூ. 83 கோடி மானியம்

இலங்கைத்

தமிழர்களுக்கு வீடுகள்

10,469 வீடுகள் கட்ட அனுமதி
6,010 வீடுகள் நிறைவு

தொல்குடி திட்டம்

ரூ. 450 கோடி மதிப்பில்
6,685 வீடுகள் மற்றும்
908 உட்கட்டமைப்பும் பணிகள்

அயோத்திதாசுப் பண்டிதர்

குடியிருப்புகள் மேம்பாட்டுத் திட்டம்

ரூ. 482 கோடி மதிப்பில்
5,281 உட்கட்டமைப்பும் பணிகள்

அன்புச்சோலைத் திட்டம்

மூத்த குடிமக்களுக்கு
28 பகல்நேரப் பராமரிப்பு மையங்கள்

தூய்மைப் பணியாளர்கள்

உணவுத் திட்டம்

இந்தியாவில் முதல்முறை -
தினசரி 1.30 இலட்சம்
பணியாளர்கள் பயன்

சமூகப் பாதுகாப்பு

35.34 இலட்சம் நபர்கள்
சமூகநலத் திட்டங்களில் பயன்

ஊட்டச்சத்தை உறுதி செய் திட்டம்

1.83 இலட்சம் குழந்தைகள் மற்றும்
தாய்மார்களுக்கு ரூ. 40.88 கோடி
மதிப்பில் சிறப்பு ஊட்டச்சத்து உணவு
78% குழந்தைகள் எடை அதிகரிப்பு

திருநங்கையர் நலன்

- மாத ஓய்வூதியம் ரூ. 1,500 ஆக உயர்வு
- ஊர்க்காவல் படையில் பணி நியமனம்
- திருநங்கையர் பாதுகாப்பிற்காக
“அரண் இல்லம்”
- உயர்கல்வி உதவித் தொகை



வெல்வோம்
ஒன்றாக!

தமிழ்நாட்டின் வளர்ச்சிப் பயணத்தில் ஒருவரையும் பின்தங்க விடமாட்டோம் !



A Special Publication from The Hindu Group

FAIRS & FESTIVALS

TRADITIONAL CUSTOMS AND ANCIENT CULTURES OF TAMIL NADU

Tamils have traditionally celebrated festivals to mark the changing seasons, and these celebrations were not confined to spring alone. Even the summer months were filled with festivals that reflected the rich cultural heritage and customs of the people. Deeply rooted in ancient customs and traditions, many of these festivals gradually assumed religious overtones. The coffee-table book Fairs and Festivals of Tamil Nadu, vividly captures the history and spirit of these celebrations through eye-catching photographs and engaging write-ups. While urbanisation has diminished the charm of some festivals, their spirit continues to endure. The book inspires readers to travel across the State and experience these vibrant festivals firsthand.

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INBRIEF



Sanctuary with lifelong refuge for rescued animals launched

An animal sanctuary and therapeutic retreat centre, ‘The Tranquile’, was formally launched as a “lifelong refuge for rescued animals” in the city on Sunday. The project is a joint initiative of I-CARE Charitable Trust, founded by animal welfare activist Shiranee Pereira and PFCI Chennai. Former Indian cricketer and coach Robin Singh, philanthropist Nina Reddy, members of the Tamil Nadu Animal Welfare Board, and representatives of animal welfare organisations, were present at the launch. The centre is envisaged as a permanent sanctuary for nearly 1,000 animals – including horses, camels, and donkeys – and birds rescued from abuse, abandonment, illegal captivity, and slaughter. Animals will be housed in open and natural enclosures, designed to allow free movement and social interaction, rather than be confined in cages or chains.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper, thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (February 23, Monday), the following explainers are available:

- Why are apple traders in J&K worried? newsth.live/applejkexp
- How proteins are being tweaked to be quantum sensors inside the body newsth.live/bodyproteins

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access this article. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access the article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Public Works Dept. set to restore two Egmore Museum buildings to former glory

The Geology and Anthropology galleries will undergo repairs; the PWD's Building Centre and Conservation Division is engaged in carrying out the work at the 16.25-acre museum complex

HERITAGE AND HISTORY

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

Two historic buildings at the Egmore Government Museum, home to the Geology and Anthropology galleries, are poised to regain their former glory as the Public Works Department (PWD) has begun meticulous restoration of the landmark structures.

The weathered walls and facades of the iconic structures, which showcase a slice of history, stand as reminders of a rich architectural past. The PWD's Building Centre and Conservation Division engaged in heritage restoration is carrying out the work at the 16.25-acre museum complex known for its Indo-Saracenic architectural style.

One among the six buildings in the complex, the Geology section, at the rear side of the Museum Theatre was built in 1851. Spread over nearly 5,500 sq.ft., the single-storey



Preserving the past: PWD officials said the restoration will be completed in a year. R. RAGU

structure with a mezzanine floor has suffered about 60% decay.

The 16-large window frames on the ground floor are now being prepared for restoration. The damaged partly panelled and partly glazed doors are set to be replaced.

Deep cracks
Pointing to the deep cracks running through the walls, an official of the PWD official said preliminary work is in progress to repair the damaged inner walls and also leaky Mangalore tile roofing. While many of the

geological exhibits have been relocated, some of the permanently fixed installations are being covered to facilitate restoration work.

Traditional ‘*Theervai*’ wall plastering work using lime mortar would be carried out with materials sourced from Virudhunagar district.

Another majestic red-bricked structure at the rear side of the Museum Theatre and Connemara Library, which houses the Anthropology gallery, also showed signs of decay. A plague embedded in

the wall states that the foundation stone for the building was laid in March 1890. PWD officials said the Anthropology block was opened in 1896 along with the Museum Theatre.

Extending over nine halls, these galleries showcase exhibits, including those related to ethnology and physical anthropology. While there is a connecting corridor to Connemara library, it has now been closed, said officials.

This building too has been damaged with water leaking from the Madras Terrace roof and seeping through the walls till the ground floor. Work on restoration of decorative art plastering on the ceiling would be taken up after discussion with conservation architect.

Officials said the restoration work also includes the fixing of teak wood glazed ventilators, coloured glass panes and heritage tiled floor, besides rainwater harvesting system and improved landscaping. The project is set to be completed in a year, considering the high footfall at the museum.



Devotees attending the *kumbabhishekam* at the Sri Raveeswarar Temple at Vyasarpadi in Chennai on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Kumbabhishekam of Raveeswarar Temple held in Vyasarpadi

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The *kumbabhishekam* of the famous Sri Raveeswarar Temple in Vyasarpadi was held on Sunday morning with thousands of devotees witnessing the event.

The temple, which got flooded every monsoon, was lifted from the ground level and now stands at 7.2 ft above the road. It used to be 4 ft. below the road level. The shrines of Sri Raveeswarar and Sri Maragathambal were lifted up, along with the Maha Mandapam and Ardhha Mandapam, as one structure with an area of 2,150 sq. ft. The majestic gopuram was also raised by 6.3 ft using jacks.

The previous *kumbabhishekam* was held on February 22, 2013. The *balalayam* for the consecration

was done on October 7, 2024.

The *sthala vriksham*, a vanni tree has been safely placed inside a wooden covering. The temple also has a younger vanni tree. The temple, where legend has it that Lord Surya is believed to have worshipped Lord Shiva in the form of a Lingam made of vanni wood and bathed in the temple tank, was renovated during the later Chola period.

The temple tank, the Surya Theertham, was renovated last year.

The temple also has shrines for Sundara Vinayakar, Saint Vallalar, Saint Vyasar, Munai Kaatha Perumal, Subramanya along with Valli and Devayanai, Iyyappan, Kaala Bhairavar, Navagraham, Anjaneyar, and 65 Nayana-mars.

Persons with disabilities take centre stage in inclusive theatre performance



Breaking barriers: The cast of the play, ‘From Stone Age to Screen Age’, put up by the Yes, We Too Can Charitable Trust.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A charitable trust on Sunday staged a theatre performance, “From Stone Age to Screen Age”, featuring a cast comprised entirely of persons with disabilities, in Chennai.

It also included sign language interpretation and

live audio description, making the performance more inclusive for the audience.

“This is the first time we are showcasing a theatre performance with our members – including 14 people with locomotor disabilities, and speech and hearing impairments. In the field of media, we do

not see more persons with disabilities acting. Since it is a commercial industry, they might not have the time to train and provide exposure. This is why we wanted to create a platform for persons with disabilities (to showcase their skills) with our CSR partner Fiserv,” says Madhavi Latha Prathigudupu of the

YWTC (Yes, We Too Can) Charitable Trust.

The one-hour play was about the journey of human beings from the prehistoric period to the current age of social media, and its consequences.

“When working with persons with disabilities, I never felt they were any different from the artistes I

worked with before. I didn't restrict them to certain roles. They performed all types of roles today, despite having only a limited number of days for practice and rehearsal,” said Arivazhagan A., the director of the play.

Sathish Kumar, one of the artistes in the play, said the next step should be to

provide opportunities for persons with disabilities to play characters that represent them. If a character in a film has a disability, it could be portrayed by a person with disability instead of a non-disabled actor, said Mr. Kumar.

Sridhar from Dummies Drama honoured the artistes.

Student from Maharashtra drowns in sea, another missing

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A woman student from Maharashtra, who had come on a picnic to Chennai with a larger group, drowned in the sea on the Kanathur beach on Saturday evening, while a male student who was washed away in the sea was missing. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has sought the help of the Tamil Nadu government to provide assistance to the family of the victims.

A senior officer of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate said a group of 26 students from Maharashtra had come on a picnic to the Kanathur beach on the East Coast Road (ECR) on Saturday.

Out of this group, three students identified as Mayuri Chaudhury, Jai Patil, and Raj Kedari, entered the water when a huge wave dragged them inside. On seeing this, the other students pulled out Mayuri and Raj, while Jai Patil could not be rescued.

The students took Mayuri and Raj to a nearby private hospital, where Mayuri was pronounced dead. With the help of local fishermen, the Kanathur police were searching for Jai, who was swept away in the sea.

In a social media post, Mr. Fadnavis sought the State government's help to expedite the search and provide all possible assistance. “The State (Maharashtra) administration remains in constant contact with the concerned families and is providing all necessary help,” he added.

According to police sources, the relatives of Mayuri and Jai have reached the city.

THE HINDU

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CINEMA ARTS EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Naada Inbam, 24992672
Today 6.15 p.m. “Organizing Manodharma” A lec dem by Vidushi Sangeetha Sivakumar, dedicated to Sangita Vidwan Music Composer L. Krishnan by his Disciples and family. Ragasudha Hall.

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4.
Today at 6.30 pm, R.S. Manohar's NXGs Proudly Presents Ramakrishna Paramahamsar Directed by S. Shivprasadh & S. Sruuthi. Ph. No: 86103 57987. Rasikas Welcome.

SRI PARTHASARATHY SWAMI SABHA
(Estd:-1900) Ph: 9444701446

DANCE FESTIVAL
at R.K. Swamy Auditorium, (Sir Sivasswamy Kalatalaya S.S. School) Sundareswarar St, Mylapore
Today-Feb 23-5.30 p.m. Bharatanatyam by **NETHRA DILIPAN** (Disciple of Guru H.N.Nandhini Suresh, Sri Sai Nrithyalaya) 7.00 p.m. B.N by **C. SOUNDARYA** (Disciple of Guru M. Lakshmi Priya Raja, Maathirika)- All Are Welcome.

Presented by: **Nalli**

MISCELLANEOUS

Narada Gana Sabha Trust
Ph: 24995201
Today - up to - 28.2.2026 - Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall)
Daily - 6.30 p.m. - “Bhagavad Gita” Chapter 2 - Discourse by Pujyarsi Sri Ramana Charna Tirtha (Nochur Swamigal). All are welcome.

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BENGALURU CENTRAL CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Superintending Engineer, Zone-2, BCCC, 4th Floor, Annex Building-3, Bengaluru – 560 002

No.: SE/BCCC/Z-2/TEND/04/2025-26 Date: 21.02.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER-CALL-3 (Only through KPP Portal) Two Cover System

The Superintending Engineer, Zone-2, BCCC, Bengaluru invites tenders from eligible Contractors firm registered in Bengaluru Central City Corporation or equivalent registration with Labour Department or any State Government Organizations for the **Collection of Parking Fees for Various roads in Bengaluru Central City Corporation, Zone-2** as detailed in the table below.

Sl. No.	Description
1	Collection of Parking Fees Dispensary Road (OPH Road) to Kamaraj Road & Ibrahim Sahib Street Road. Minimum Reserve Annual License fee (Rs in Lakhs): 95.22, EMD (In Rs): 1,90,440/-.
2	Collection of Parking Fees for Millers Road Junction, Planetarium Road, St. John's Church Road & St. John's Road. Minimum Reserve Annual License fee (Rs in Lakhs): 113.23, EMD (In Rs): 2,00,000/-.
3	Collection of Parking Fees for 2nd temple road in Dattatreya Temple Ward, Sampige Road, Railway Parallel Road & BVK Iyengar road. Minimum Reserve Annual License fee (Rs in Lakhs): 96.1, EMD (In Rs): 1,92,200/-.
4	Collection of Parking Fees for Mavalli Tank Bund road, DVG Road in Sunkenahalli Ward, Shankarmat Road & PMK Road. Minimum Reserve Annual License fee (Rs in Lakhs): 109.38, EMD (In Rs): 2,00,000/-.
5	Collection of Parking Fees for Vani Vilas Road, Vasavi Temple Street, Kanakapura Road, Diagonal Road, Patalamma Road & T Mariyappa Road. Minimum Reserve Annual License fee (Rs in Lakhs): 122.34, EMD (In Rs): 2,00,000/-.

Period of Tender: 3 Years + 2 years of extension.

Calendar of events: (1) Tender documents may be downloaded from the KPP portal of the Government of Karnataka from **23.02.2026.** (2) Queries may be uploaded in KPP Portal on or before: **03.03.2026** upto **4:00 p.m.** (3) Tenders must be submitted online through KPP portal on or before **4:00 p.m. on 07.03.2026** and the opening of tenders will be as per e-procurement portal guidelines. (4) Technical Bids will be opened on the website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> in the office of the Superintending Engineer, Zone-2, BCCC, Bengaluru on **09.03.2026** at **4:30 p.m.** Further details can be obtained from the above office during working hours or from the website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

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I, OLD given Name: THULASI DHASAS, Old Surname: SEKKIAH, born on 13.07.1958, residing at 40, Jayabalan Street, Vasudevan Nagar, Jafferkanpet, Chennai-600083, shall henceforth be known as New Given Name: THULASIDASS, New Surname: SEKKIAH.

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TENDERS

CHRISTIAN MEDICAL COLLEGE VELLORE
Ida Scudder Road, Vellore-4, TN.

Timeline Extension - Prequalification of Interior Contractors

CMC Vellore, Chittoor Campus seeks experienced and reputed Interior Contractors for the Interior Finishing & Fit-out works of its 400-bedded Teaching Hospital (7,32,904 sq.ft.) under construction located at 190 Ramapuram, 189 Kothapalli Post, Gudipala Mandal, Chittoor-517132, Andhra Pradesh.

Interested contractors may obtain prequalification documents from The Engineering Planning Office, Christian Medical College Vellore, Ida Scudder Road, Vellore – 632004, Tamil Nadu from 23rd February 2026 onwards in person or download from the web site www.cmch-vellore.edu →Tender Notice → Download CMC Vellore Chittoor Campus Teaching Hospital - PQ Interiors.

Completed applications supported by prescribed documents should be submitted to The General Superintendent, Christian Medical College Vellore, Ida Scudder Road, Vellore-632004, Tamil Nadu, on or before 09th March 2026.

Note: Contractor firms that have already expressed their interest in response to the previous advertisement need not apply.

TENDERS

CHRISTIAN MEDICAL COLLEGE VELLORE
Ida Scudder Road, Vellore-4, TN.

Timeline Extension - Prequalification of Contractors

CMC Vellore, Chittoor Campus seeks experienced and reputed Contractors for the complete façade works for the 400-bedded Teaching Hospital (7,32,904 sq.ft.) under construction located at 190 Ramapuram, 189 Kothapalli Post, Gudipala Mandal, Chittoor-517132, Andhra Pradesh.

Interested contractors may obtain prequalification documents from The Engineering Planning Office, Christian Medical College Vellore, Ida Scudder Road, Vellore – 632004, Tamil Nadu from 23rd February 2026 onwards in person or download from the web site www.cmch-vellore.edu →Tender Notice → Download CMC Vellore Chittoor Campus Teaching Hospital - PQ Facade.

Completed applications supported by prescribed documents should be submitted to The General Superintendent, Christian Medical College Vellore, Ida Scudder Road, Vellore-632004, Tamil Nadu, on or before 09th March 2026.

Note: Contractor firms that have already expressed their interest in response to the previous advertisement need not apply.

TENDERS

CHRISTIAN MEDICAL COLLEGE VELLORE
Ida Scudder Road, Vellore-4, TN.

Timeline Extension - Prequalification of Turnkey Contractors

CMC Vellore, Chittoor Campus proposes to develop Housing Blocks (Type BCD, LIQ/MIQ) and a Community Hall with a total built-up area of 1,28,961 sq.ft.(G+4), located at 190 Ramapuram, 189 Kothapalli Post, Gudipala Mandal, Chittoor-517132, Andhra Pradesh.

Interested contractors may obtain prequalification documents from The Engineering Planning Office, Christian Medical College Vellore, Ida Scudder Road, Vellore – 632004, Tamil Nadu from 23rd February 2026 onwards in person or download from the web site www.cmch-vellore.edu →Tender Notice → Download CMC Vellore Chittoor Campus Teaching Hospital - PQ Housing.

Completed applications supported by prescribed documents should be submitted to The General Superintendent, Christian Medical College Vellore, Ida Scudder Road, Vellore-632004, Tamil Nadu, on or before 09th March 2026.

Note: Contractor firms that have already expressed their interest in response to the previous advertisement need not apply.

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GCC asks Kodungaiyur waste incinerator to stop operations over public health concerns

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has issued a notice ordering the Kodungaiyur waste incinerator plant to stop operations.

According to the notice issued by the Superintending Engineer of the Solid Waste Management Department on Friday, the firm had been ordered to

“immediately suspend the operation of the incinerator plant with effect from receipt of this letter and submit within three days a detailed compliance report covering all 48 environmental parameters prescribed by TNPCB (Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board)”.

A joint inspection was carried out on February 18 by officials of the TNPCB, GCC and the District Revenue Officer/Assistant Commissioner, Zone - 4.

During the inspection, the following deficiencies were observed: the water scrubber system was found to be inadequate to effectively control emissions; poor housekeeping was noticed on the premises; a huge backlog of unprocessed waste had accumulated within the facility; and more than 100 tonnes of bottom ash was

stored at the site.

Pointing to the deficiencies that indicated serious operational lapses and non-compliance with statutory environmental norms and the conditions stipulated in the concession agreement, the civic body stressed the need for installation and operationalisation of a continuous emission monitoring system (CEMS) integrated with TNPCB servers.

☀️🌧️	Timings
CHENNAI	
MONDAY, FEB. 23	
☀️ RISE	06:28
🌅 SET	18:17
🌙 RISE	10:30
🌅 SET	23:44
TUESDAY, FEB. 24	
☀️ RISE	06:28
🌅 SET	18:17
🌙 RISE	11:23
🌅 SET	00:00
WEDNESDAY, FEB. 25	
☀️ RISE	06:27
🌅 SET	18:17
🌙 RISE	12:21
🌅 SET	00:47

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	32	21
Chennai Airport	33	25
Chennai City	32	26

Chennai Airport Today
33°C The morning will be pleasant. The day will be warm. The night also will be pleasant. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
34°C The weather will be dry. The day will be warm. The night will be pleasant.

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THE HINDU
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18 Years



B.Joseph
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14 Years



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Resident Manager (Estates & Trust)
13 Years



T.Avudayappan
Field Executive
13 Years



G.Padma
Manager (Admin)
12 Years

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The Felicitation function will be held today at 3rd floor of our office between 4 to 5 pm



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M CH-CHE

DPR of Chennai Port’s outer harbour project to be ready by June

The financial model for implementing the ₹10,000-cr. project is being finalised; the outer harbour will feature deeper draught and modern berthing facilities to handle large vessels



Marine initiative: The project, which will be implemented in a phased manner, aims to increase capacity, improve logistics time, and reduce cost. FILE PHOTO

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Chennai Port’s ambitious outer harbour project, which is set to be revived for the third time, is estimated to cost nearly ₹10,000 crore. Its detailed project report is expected to be ready by June this year.

The project is essential as the port aims at handling some of the world’s largest vessels, whose carrying capacity exceeds 20,000 twenty-foot equivalent unit.

Since the existing inner harbour has certain limitations with respect to draft and berth

The project did not take off earlier as it required huge investment from the firm securing the contract

length, the outer harbour – planned with deeper draught and modern berthing facilities – will help handle such vessels.

The project, which will be implemented in a phased manner, also promises to increase capacity, improve logistics time, and reduce cost.

Recently, the Chennai Port Authority awarded a contract to a transac-

tion advisor.

While a DPR was prepared many years ago, some parts of the document need to be revised. “The layout and other such aspects will remain the same. It is the cost and financial model that require modifications. Initially, it was estimated that the project would require nearly ₹8,000 crore, but the revised estimate stands at about ₹10,000 crore,” a source said.

The port is still finalising the financial model to implement the project. One of the reasons the project did not take off earlier was that it required a huge invest-

ment from the firm securing the contract.

PPP model

But now, the port is looking at the Hybrid Annuity Model, a public-private partnership (PPP) framework.

“If this model is approved by the Board, the port will provide 60% of the cost, while the remaining 40% will come from the firm,” another source said.

After this, the Chennai Port Authority must get environment clearance and approval from the Union government. Only then can the port call for bids for the project construction.

Low-pressure area likely to bring rain in Western Ghat districts

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Regional Meteorological Centre, Chennai, said that the well-marked low-pressure area over the southwest Bay of Bengal recurred northeastwards gradually and lay over the same region at 5.30 p.m. on Sunday.

It is very likely to continue to move further northeastwards over southwest Bay of Bengal during the next 36 hours.

It is expected to bring light to moderate rain at isolated places in Western Ghat districts.

The RMC has forecast dry weather over the rest of Tamil Nadu, and Pudukcherry and Karaikal area on Monday and Tuesday.

Mist to prevail

Mist or haze is likely to prevail in isolated pockets of Salem, Dharmapuri, Krishnagiri, Tirupattur, Vellore, Ranipet, Tiruvallur, Chennai, and Kancheepuram in the early morning hours of Monday and Tuesday.

On Sunday, rainfall occurred at isolated places over the State (at a few places over south coastal Tamil Nadu and at isolated places over rest of the State), while dry weather prevailed over Pudukcherry and Karaikal area.



The GCC Council passed a resolution empowering the Chief Vector Control Officer to procure larvicides recently.

GCC plans to appoint entomologists to control vector-borne diseases across city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In view of the rise in complaints about vector-borne and zoonotic diseases in the city, the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) Council on Friday passed a resolution delegating powers to the Chief Vector Control Officer (CVCO) and appointing additional entomologists for the prevention of diseases.

The CVCO has been empowered to procure larvicides and adulticides and fogging machines, and fill vacancies to various posts, including the post for malaria control workers, under compassionate grounds.

The GCC Council passed another resolution to appoint entomologists at the regional offices for strengthening mosquito and pest control across the city.

At a meeting conducted on February 7, GCC Commissioner J. Kuma-

ragurubaran suggested the appointment of senior entomologists in each region of the Chennai Corporation.

Reports on diseases

The Regional Entomologists will submit reports on malaria, dengue, chikungunya, filariasis, encephalitis, scrub typhus and leptospirosis to the regional deputy commissioners and take measures to promote public health.

They will get inspection vehicles with drivers, data entry operators, and office assistants.

Pointing to the role played by the Vector Control Department, the civic body said the vacancies in the department would be filled. Currently, there are 181 vacancies in the post of basic health workers. A total of 1,142 permanent malaria control workers have been employed by the GCC and 2,450 workers hired temporarily.

Chennai Corporation to deploy sanitation workers through women’s self-help groups

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has announced a series of measures to strengthen solid waste management across the city.

The measures include deployment of sanitation workers through women’s self-help groups (SHGs), domestic hazardous waste management, and bio-mining of legacy waste.

According to GCC officials, the civic body plans to engage conservancy workers through SHGs in several zones.

In Ambattur, 1,457 workers will be deployed for 90

days at a cost of ₹9.96 crore, and in Teynampet, 114 workers will be deployed for one year, involving an outgo of ₹3.16 crore.

Perungudi will get 181 workers for one year at ₹5.02 crore; Sholinganallur 160 workers at ₹4.44 crore; Manali 115 workers at ₹3.19 crore; and Adyar 267 workers at ₹7.16 crore.

In Tondiarpet, 550 workers will be deployed for 37 days at ₹1.54 crore.

The calculated gross daily allocation per sanitation worker deployed through SHGs in zones such as Ambattur is ₹759, as against the officially mandated daily wage of ₹761 for unskilled

conservancy workers.

The GCC will also collect, transport, process and dispose of domestic hazardous waste across all 15 zones for one year at ₹6.49 crore.

Buttermilk for workers

The GCC will also provide buttermilk to workers during summer.

The second phase of bio-mining of legacy waste at the Perungudi dump yard will be taken up at an estimated ₹53.60 crore.

Bio-mining is under way at the Kodungaiyur dump yard, processing 25 lakh tonnes out of 67 lakh tonnes so far.

GCC Commissioner J. Kumaragurubaran said on X

that trees would be planted on the reclaimed land parcel.

‘Need salary revision’

Noting that several schemes had been proposed for sanitation workers, Tiruvottiyur councillor R. Jayaraman said a salary revision should also be announced.

He pointed out that the incinerator at the Kodungaiyur Waste-to-Energy plant was yet to be scrapped.

While welcoming the rope car project at the Marina, the CPI(M) councillor said the livelihoods of many vendors had been affected after they were removed from the stretch developed under the Blue Flag programme.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

BRAHMASHRI SHRI Subramania Sastrigal (93) ex Principal, Rajaveda Kavaya Patasala Kumbakonam, passed away peacefully and cremated on 22-02-2026. Dasahasthu on 03/03/26 at 52/12-1, Kasiraman street, Kumbakonam. Smt. Jayalakshmi, Sri S Ganesan -CUB & Smt Bhuvana , Sri S Sriram- USA & Smt Shubha, Sri T R Vasudevan & Smt Bhooma and Sri S.Swaminathan & Smt Uma. Grand son- Pranav and Granddaughters Priya, Aparna, Lavanya & Niranjana. Ph: 9080000180

DEATH



Smt VIJAYA DORAISWAMY

(01.08.1940 - 19.02.2026)

W/o Late Sri V. Doraiswamy I.A.&A.S.

(Addl. Dy Comptroller and Auditor General of India) attained the Lotus Feet of Sri Sathguru Gnanananda Sarasvathi Ma on Thursday. The last rites were held on Friday.

Deeply mourned by

Children:

Padmavathi Padmanabhan; D Rajiv Krishnan and Sujata; Nitya and Ravi Gopalakrishnan;

Grandchildren:

Mukund Krishna and Krithika, Nalini, Kalyani and Great Granddaughter: Dhriti.

Contact:

Padma: 9444044274; Rajiv: 9632548005; Nitya: 9980518509

DEATH

OBITUARY



She smiled She conquered

SMT SHYAMALA SUNDARAM

D.O.B: 22.02.2026

W/O Maj.Gen.C.Sundaram AVSM

Deeply mourned by

Mrs.Padmini Dorairajan

Mrs. Maya & Mr.Shyam Sunder

Dr.Siddharth Dorairajan & Mrs.Vanitha

Dr.Smritha Dorairajan & Dr.C.Anand

Mr.Nikil Shyam Sunder & Mrs. Priya

Kavin, Laya, Taruni, Krithik, Kai

Funeral : 23.02.2026, 3.00 Pm

98400 46366 / 98407 80017

DEATH

SAD DEMISE



It is with deep sorrow that I announce the passing away of my beloved wife,

Mrs. Jamuna Jeevarathanam
(18.12.1957 – 22.02.2026)

Wife of **Mr. R.S. Jeevarathanam, B.A., B.L.,**

Senior Advocate, Madras High Court

Plot No. 919, 13th Main Road, Anna Nagar, Chennai - 600040.

Funeral services will be held at 11:00 a.m. on 24th February 2026.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FIRST ANNIVERSARY



D. KALYANASUNDARAM

Retd. ADC of Police & Ex-CGS of Lucas TVS

26-Sep-1947 to 23-Feb-2025

In loving memory of our dear father missed beyond words, remembered with love.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

14th ANNIVERSARY



HELEN JAYASEELI MARCUS

23.02.2012

Remembering with Love

John Marcus, Edgar Masscarnes

Amma & Joshua

DEATH

OBITUARY



We regret to inform that

Sri. C.L. Ramakrishnan

passed away peacefully on

Sunday 22.02.2026

In Grief

Family Members

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

SIXTH YEAR ANNIVERSARY



Mr. R.P. SAMY

Mis. NATIONAL SWITCHGEARS Co

17.02.1947 - 23.02.2020

Your vibrant presence still lives in our

thoughts and forever in our hearts. We

deeply respect your strong values which

will continue to inspire us always.

Remembered fondly by

Family members

Devi Kumari, Raj & Uma,

Jaya & Nagarajan, Krithika,

Karthik & Diya

Staff of NATIONAL SWITCHGEARS

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

SECOND YEAR ANNIVERSARY



M S SABESAN

BE (CEG) M.Tech (IIT-M)

DOB: 16.06.1952 - DOD: 23.02.2024

STRUCTURAL CONSULTANT

- M S BUILDERS

Fondly Remembered by

Dr. D.Gandhimathi, Dr. SS Aravind,

Dr. SS Lavanya & Grandchildren

Phone: +91 98843 24308

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A Space Marketing Initiative
Monday, February 23, 2026

Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals - Swift advanced aortic care saves two lives in critical emergencies

Dr. Venkateshwar Ravi, Interventional Vascular Surgeon at Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals, discusses evolving approaches to aortic repair, limb-saving procedures, and efforts towards reducing amputations in Tamil Nadu.



AN AWARENESS FEATURE HIGHLIGHTING VASCULAR HEALTH, EARLY DETECTION, PREVENTIVE CARE, AND TIMELY LIFE-SAVING INTERVENTIONS

The aorta, the body's largest blood vessel is responsible for carrying oxygen-rich blood from the heart to the rest of the body. When this vital artery develops a tear or swelling, the consequences can be sudden and life-threatening. At Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals, advanced minimally invasive vascular procedures are helping patients survive such critical conditions with safer outcomes and faster recovery.

A Second Chance at a New Life

A 45 year old man undergoing regular dialysis and preparing for a long-awaited kidney transplant experienced sudden severe chest pain. Investigations revealed a Type B Aortic Dissection, a dangerous tear in the inner wall of the aorta that can become fatal if untreated.

We performed a highly advanced TEVAR (Thoracic Endovascular Aortic Repair) procedure to seal the tear from within the artery. A carotid-to-subclavian artery bypass was also performed to ensure uninterrupted blood supply to the left hand.



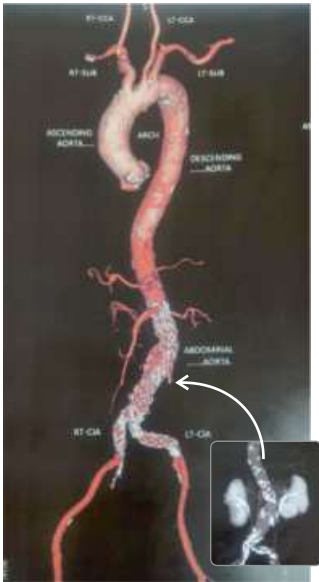
TEVAR

“We were able to treat the condition without open chest surgery, significantly reducing risk and recovery time.” The minimally invasive approach resulted in minimal blood loss, quicker healing, and a stable recovery. Today, the patient is back on track to pursue his kidney transplant - his dream restored.

Two Critical Concerns One Coordinated Plan

In another complex case, a 65 year old patient presented with severe abdominal pain and was diagnosed with biliary sepsis caused by gallstones blocking the bile duct. Further evaluation revealed an abdominal aortic aneurysm, a balloon-like swelling in the aorta that carries a high risk of rupture.

The multidisciplinary team adopted a carefully staged approach: Emergency ERCP to relieve the bile duct



EVAR

blockage; Cholecystectomy to eliminate the infection source; Stabilization and control of sepsis; followed by EVAR (Endovascular Aneurysm Repair) to repair the aneurysm from within the blood vessel. By addressing the infection first and the aneurysm next, the team ensured the safest possible outcome. The patient responded well to treatment and is now stable.

Vascular Health: A Growing Public Health Concern

While emergency procedures such as aortic repair draw attention, a large number of vascular conditions develop very gradually and often remain undetected until serious complications arise. A vascular surgeon treats disorders affecting arteries and veins throughout the body including



blockages in the legs, diabetic foot complications, stroke prevention carotid disease, aneurysms, vascular injuries in trauma and venous disorders.

Many of these conditions are closely linked to diabetes, hypertension, smoking, and high cholesterol, all of which are increasingly prevalent. Early detection significantly improves outcomes.

Preventing Avoidable Amputations

One of the most pressing concerns in Tamil Nadu is limb loss related to diabetes and Peripheral Artery Disease (PAD). PAD reduces blood flow to the legs. Early symptoms may appear like mild leg pain while walking, numbness in the feet, slow healing wounds, which are often ignored.

When left untreated, reduced circulation can lead to infection, tissue damage, and eventually amputation. However, advances in vascular medicine have made limb salvage increasingly possible. Minimally invasive procedures such as angioplasty and stenting can reopen blocked arteries and restore blood flow. With timely intervention, many amputations are preventable.

Towards an Amputation-Free Tamil Nadu

Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals is working towards raising awareness about early vascular evaluation, particularly among diabetic patients. The focus includes screening high-risk individuals, early referral for non-healing wounds, restoring circulation before irreversible damage occurs, and coordination by a multidisciplinary team - diabetologist, general surgeon, plastic surgeon, orthopedician, vascular surgeon specialists.

Amputation should be the last resort. With early vascular evaluation and timely intervention, most limbs can be saved.

— Dr. Venkateshwar Ravi



Amputation should be the last resort, not the first line of management.

When to Seek Help

A vascular consultation should be considered if there is leg pain while walking, persistent foot wounds, discoloration of toes, sudden severe chest, back, or abdominal pain, or



swelling in one limb. Timely evaluation can prevent both life-threatening complications and limb loss.

Advanced Technology. Compassionate Care

With the latest advanced EVAR and TEVAR procedures, Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals offers smaller incisions, shorter hospital stay, reduced surgical risk, faster return to normal life, and better outcomes for high-risk patients. By combining world-class endovascular technology with compassionate patient-centered care, the hospital continues to set new benchmarks in advanced vascular and aortic treatment, saving lives, preserving limbs, and restoring hope.

For more information visit
<https://www.drkmh.com/vascular-and-endovascular-surgery>

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INBRIEF



DMK strongest in western region, says Udhayanidhi

“The DMK is strongest in western region,” Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin said at the party’s West Region Youth Wing conference in Kaniyur, Coimbatore, on Sunday. Addressing functionaries from 39 constituencies, he said the DMK had appointed administrators in every booth, while other parties were still working out their booth-level structure. Referring to the *Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thittam*, he alleged that the BJP had planned to move court to stall the ₹1,000 monthly assistance scheme. If re-elected, he said, the monthly assistance would be increased to ₹2,000. Referring to the Union Budget, he claimed it contained no major allocations for the State, and it demonstrated the Centre’s disregard for the State’s interests. The Assembly election will be a “democratic war” between Tamil Nadu and Delhi, he said. Referring to AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, he said the AIADMK had been “sold” to the BJP.

Spectator dies of injuries inflicted by charging bull

S. Gunasekaran, a 47-year-old wage labourer, who had gone to witness a bull-run event, was killed due to injuries inflicted by a charging bull at Perumalpattu village near Tirupattur town on Sunday. He was the second victim to have died during such events in the region. Recently, a 65-year-old man died during a bull race in Vellore. Police said when Gunasekaran tried to cross the muddy track, where bulls were allowed to run, he was hit by the charging bull, and sustained injuries on his chest. He was rushed to Government Taluk Hospital in Tirupattur town, where doctors declared him brought dead. A case was registered and further probe is on.

Palayamkottai clock, ‘older than Big Ben’, to chime again

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI



The year 1854 is engraved on the clock.

When antique clock collector Robert Kennedy and master clocksmith Nagaraj climbed the bell tower of the historic Holy Trinity Cathedral at Palayamkottai in Tirunelveli district to inspect its tower clock recently, they were thrilled to make a remarkable discovery: the timepiece predates the Great Bell of the Great Clock at the Palace of Westminster, London, nicknamed Big Ben.

“Big Ben was installed in 1859, whereas this clock was manufactured in 1854 and installed in 1855. It was made by John Moore & Sons of Clerkenwell, a renowned London-based clockmaker,” said Mr. Kennedy, who has been invited by the church authorities to examine the mechanism and undertake its restoration. The year 1854 is engraved on the clock.

The cathedral itself, built in 1826 by Rev. C.T.E. Rhenius, recently celebrated its bicentenary, adding further historical significance to the restoration effort.

Although the clock continues to function, it has fallen silent in recent years, unable to deliver its once sonorous chime owing to a technical defect. Mr. Kennedy, who exa-

mined other clocks in the country, is also of the view that the Holy Trinity Cathedral clock could be the oldest tower clock in India.

After repeated but unsuccessful attempts to restore the bell’s chime, the church authorities contemplated installing a battery-operated mechanism as a substitute. They approached Mr. Kennedy and, following two months of deliberations, he agreed to take up the challenge alongside Mr. Nagaraj, with whom he has restored numerous antique clocks to their former glory.

He was unequivocal in his opposition to replacing the original mechanism. After inspecting the clock, Mr. Nagaraj found the fault lay in the chiming section.

“Tower clocks are meant to be wound week-

Over 300 textile mills closed down in T.N. in last few years: report

Many small-scale mills have shut due to rising input costs, steep hike in power tariff, and high cost of borrowing, says spinning mills association

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Over 300 textile mills went out of operation in Tamil Nadu between 2021-22 and 2023-24, according to the Annual Survey of Industries.

The data released by the Union Ministry of Textiles earlier this month showed that in 2021-22, Tamil Nadu had 2,773 textile mills and 2,121 of these were in operation. In 2023-24, the number went down to 2,455 with just 1,672 mills in operation. Spokesperson of a leading textile association said another 300 mills were closed in the last two years.

According to industry representatives, almost two lakh powerlooms ended operations in the last couple of years. A host of factors has hit the textile industry in the State, they say. Most of the textile industries are in the micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) segment. Be it raw material, bank interest rates, or power cost, the MSMEs are at a disadvantage. So, a large number of small-scale textile mills have shut shop, said South India Spinning Mills Association (SISPA) secretary Jagadish Chandran.

“The Tamil Nadu textile



Chronic stress: The textile mills in the State lost heavily on the raw material front, say industry sources. M. PERIASAMY

Textile mills lose heavily on the raw material front. Be it cotton, polyester, or viscose, the mills buy raw material from the north and incur transportation cost

industry is finding it increasingly difficult to remain cost competitive compared with other States. For instance, power cost for the mills in Tamil Nadu is ₹9.25 a unit. This is at least ₹1 more compared with competing States.

Only those textile units that have invested in wind and solar energy have survived as Tamil Nadu has the most flexible renewable energy policy. The an-

nual increase in power bills should stop,” said the spokesperson.

Textile mills lose heavily on the raw material front. Be it cotton, polyester, or viscose, the mills buy raw material from the north and incur transportation cost. The import duty on cotton and quality control orders that are now withdrawn had impacted the industry.

The processing units incur high costs because of zero liquid discharge requirements while States such as Gujarat permit marine discharge of treated effluent.

While the State government recently come out with an integrated textile policy, it should remove caps for subsidies, industry representatives said.

Railway moots more underpasses for wild elephants in forest ranges of Coimbatore

Wilson Thomas
COIMBATORE

The Palakkad Division of the Southern Railway is planning to construct more than two underpasses for wild elephants on the railway line passing through Solakkarai reserve forest of Madukkarai range.

Officials said underpasses are being planned on both ‘B’ and ‘A’ lines of the twin single line connecting Tamil Nadu and Kerala. Trains plying on Palakkad-Coimbatore direction are generally routed through ‘B’ line and the ‘A’ line is used for traffic on the opposite direction. Two such underpasses constructed by the Railways on ‘B’ line in 2023 and 2024 are being used by wild elephants to cross the track safely.

Sources in Palakkad Division said locations of the proposed underpasses will be finalised soon for further procedures. A total of 28 incidents of wild elephants getting hit while crossing railway tracks, mostly resulting in fatality, were reported between Kottakad in Palakkad district and Ettimadai in Coimbatore district from 2002 to 2024. The last death of an elephant was in Kerala, when a juvenile tusker was knocked down by a train at Vattappara near Walayar on February 4. Sources said the Palakkad Division has erected fences using



Underpasses help elephants cross the track without climbing them.

old rails on both sides of the vulnerable stretches between Walayar and Ettimadai as physical barriers. An elephant intrusion detection system (EIDS) installed by the Division for 35 km between Kottakad and Ettimadai at a cost of ₹20 crore is in the testing stage now.

The EIDS uses optical fibre-based sensing network with artificial intelligence-driven analytical modules to detect the presence of elephants near railway tracks to generate alerts.

Speed restrictions, maximum of 65 km/h during the day and 45 km/h from 6 p.m. to 6 a.m., are applicable for trains passing through the forest areas of Madukkarai range. A braking distance of about 250 metres is required for a train moving at 65 kmph and around 180 metres when the speed is 45 kmph, sources said.

About 8,100 acres of lands belonging to 1,055 temples retrieved, says HR&CE Dept.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

About 8,107.03 acres of lands that belonged to 1,055 temples, whose worth was estimated at ₹8,436 crore, were retrieved from private encroachers during the past five years, the Hindu Religious and Charitable (HR&CE) Endowments Department said on Sunday.

Besides, 2.38 lakh acres of temple lands were measured using DGPS rover land survey and F-line stones were installed in 1,50,221 locations, an official release said.

A sum of ₹212 crore has been earmarked for the renovation fund for 5,000 temples in Adi Dravida and tribal habitations as well as 5,000 temples in rural areas. The installation of three statues of Lord Murugan, all over 100 feet tall, were under way in three temples in the State, it said.

The release said conservation and renovation of temples more than 1,000 years old were undertaken in 352 temples during the past five years at a cost of ₹560 crore.

Kudamuzhukku was performed in 4,332 temples where it was not performed for over 400 years, it said.

It also mentioned the construction of a Vallalar International Centre in Vadalur at ₹99.90 crore.

Advertisement for Government Certificate Professional Course on Digital Marketing with Artificial Intelligence. Includes course details, fees, and contact information.

Advertisement for 'Your feedback will keep us Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder' by The Hindu Businessline. Includes a QR code and contact details.

Advertisement for National Highways Authority of India (Ministry of Road Transport and Highways). Includes recruitment notice for technical staff.

StartupTN advertisement for e-Procurement Short Tender Notice. Includes details about the tender process and contact information.

Advertisement for PM Shri Kendriya Vidyalaya, Island Grounds, Chennai. Includes details about the appointment of contractual teachers.

Advertisement for the Commissionerate of GST and Central Excise in Puducherry. Includes details about the election expenditure norms and the role of the Commissioner.

Three persons die as car and two-wheeler collide

The Hindu Bureau
RAMANATHAPURAM

Three persons died when a car and a two-wheeler collided near Mandapam in Ramanathapuram on Sun-

day. The victims were Tamilmani, 34, of Tiruppur, his wife Felicia, 30, of Sattur, his mother Sumathi – all occupants of the car – and an unidentified man riding the two-wheeler.



CM
Y
K



Tariffs in trouble

The U.S. Supreme Court has done well to limit Trump's presidential powers

In a major blow to a central pillar of U.S. President Donald Trump's foreign policy, the country's Supreme Court (SCOTUS) has ruled by a 6-3 margin that his use of the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) to impose tariffs on numerous countries is not in accordance with law and must be struck down. With Chief Justice John Roberts and two other conservative justices appointed by Mr. Trump siding with the three liberal justices on the subject, the Court ruled that Mr. Trump's assertion of "extraordinary power to unilaterally impose tariffs of unlimited amount, duration, and scope", is contravened by the absence of "clear congressional authorization" to exercise it. It also observed that the IEEPA contained no reference to tariffs or duties and that the executive had not identified any statute that used the word "regulate" to authorise taxation. Arguing that until now no President has read IEEPA to confer such power, the SCOTUS concluded that all the evidence available and its reading of the statutes implied that the Court believed that "IEEPA does not authorize the President to impose tariffs." Unsurprisingly, Mr. Trump reacted angrily on social media, posting that he would be raising his global tariff rate to 15%, after initially suggesting that it would be imposed at 10%, under the authority conferred to the White House for 150 days under Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974. Tariffs imposed under laws other than the IEEPA, including those on aluminium and steel under Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962, are unaffected by this ruling although Mr. Trump would face challenges in bringing fresh tariff rounds under this umbrella.

While multiple countries were slapped with tariffs earlier, including India at a whopping overall rate of 50% owing to Washington's objections to New Delhi purchasing oil from Russia, the impact of the SCOTUS ruling will vary based on the specifics of trade agreements struck, if any. Indian negotiators seeking to conclude the terms of a free trade agreement would not be blamed for feeling like they were suspended in limbo after the ruling has changed the terms of debate on which sectors to open up to concessionary rates in bilateral trade, especially after the American side's punitive potential has now been defanged to an extent. At a broader level, the ruling is to be welcomed by anyone valuing robust democratic checks and balances. The two administrations of Mr. Trump have stretched, and in some cases exceeded, the scope of permissible policy actions under domestic and international law. Until this ruling by the court, there has been a deafening silence on containing such actions by institutions rooted in constitutional authority that are capable of imposing a countervailing force.

Lines in the sand

The Pax Silica alliance holds benefits, but could also tie India down

India's entry into the Pax Silica alliance represents a strategic manoeuvre to secure its technological future by aligning with a U.S.-led coalition focused on the infrastructure for Artificial Intelligence (AI) and critical minerals. Its membership could boost domestic industrial goals by complementing initiatives such as India Semiconductor, IndiaAI, and National Critical Mineral Missions. By joining this ecosystem, India will aim to secure raw materials supply and advanced equipment, attract investment, and influence global tech and security standards. India does not currently possess significant capacity in processing critical minerals nor does it extract them in large quantities. That said, for the rest of the world, including the Pax Silica group, the more important implication is in India's potential to shift the centre of gravity for global manufacturing and consumption. India's massive demand can be useful to financially justify new supply chains, especially ones not pegged to China; the country can also provide the engineering talent and assembly capacity required to diversify the global technology supply chain. India's participation could also add significant geopolitical weight to the bloc's efforts to establish democratic governance for critical technologies, rendering the coalition's standards more viable.

Of course, there is no such thing as a free lunch. The implications for India include potential economic retaliation from China, such as trade friction, slower market access, or pressure on upstream inputs such as minerals and active pharmaceutical ingredients. The Pax Silica partnership's focus on "trusted ecosystems" could also translate into rigid expectations regarding export controls and technology-transfer guardrails, which could clash with India's preference for not locking itself into alliances but, instead, pursuing what External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar has called "issue-based alignments". The government could open itself up to more criticism at home particularly if the U.S.-led bloc also begins to shape India's domestic AI rules in ways that look externally driven. Smaller Indian firms attempting to join global value chains could also face significant financial burdens and longer timelines due to stricter security audit requirements. In the end, the success of Pax Silica will depend on whether its partners go beyond talks to build a real-world supply chain where raw minerals are mined, refined, turned into chips, and used to power AI systems, all among the pact's members, creating a secure technology network that drives India's economic growth while protecting the alliance from disruptions.

Parliament's historic law, an extended wait for women

When Parliament passed the Women's Reservation Act in September 2023, millions of Indian women believed that their moment had finally arrived. One-third of all Lok Sabha and State Assembly seats would be reserved for them. The legislation was hailed as a historic victory for gender justice, ending decades of parliamentary stalemate. But the Act contains a clause that changes everything: reservation will begin only "after the first Census taken after the year 2026" and the subsequent delimitation of constituencies. Thus, on the Act's own terms, implementation in 2029 is constitutionally impossible.

This is not a political prediction. It is a legal and logistical certainty. The next general election will be held in 2029 – before the constitutional prerequisites can be completed. Unless Parliament amends the Constitution again, Indian women cannot exercise their guaranteed representation until at least 2034.

The constitutional roadblock

The timeline is unforgiving. The Act mandates two sequential steps: first, a national Census; second, a delimitation exercise based on that Census data. Both are constitutionally required. Neither can be bypassed.

The next Census is scheduled for 2027. After enumeration, the data must be verified, compiled, and officially published – a process that, historically, has taken between 12 to 18 months. Only after official publication can the President of India constitute a Delimitation Commission under Article 82.

That Commission then faces an unprecedented task: redrawing 543 parliamentary constituencies and over 4,000 State Assembly constituencies. As this writer examined in these pages recently, the Commission must balance population distribution, administrative boundaries, geographic compactness, community representation, and the creation of reserved constituencies for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and now women.

India has constituted four Delimitation Commissions since Independence. Not one completed its work in fewer than three years. The most recent, established in 2002, took six years –and it was an exercise which only redrew internal boundaries without reallocating seats among States. The next Commission will be far more complex, reallocating seats among States for the first time since 1976 while implementing women's reservation simultaneously.

Even on the most optimistic timeline – Census completed in 2027, data published by early 2029, the Commission working with unusual speed – delimitation cannot conclude before 2032 or 2033. But these days, anything is possible. Without a new constitutional amendment removing the Census-delimitation linkage,



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women's reservation cannot be implemented in 2029. Was this delay accidental or by design? The political arithmetic provides the answer. If reservation was implemented immediately within the existing 543-seat Lok Sabha, 181 constituencies would become women-only, displacing an equal number of male incumbents overnight. No political party wanted to bear that electoral cost.

The solution was elegant in its political logic: tie reservation to delimitation. After the 2027 Census, when constituencies are redrawn, the total number of Lok Sabha seats is expected to increase substantially – possibly to around 800, perhaps even 888. With an enlarged House, one-third of seats can be reserved for women without displacing current male Members of Parliament.

The political pain is absorbed by expansion rather than replacement. This explains the mechanism. It does not justify the consequence: another decade-long delay for half of India's population.

A history of waiting

Indian women have already waited several years for this legislation. The first Women's Reservation Bill was introduced in 1996. It was debated, amended, reintroduced, and blocked repeatedly. The Bill lapsed with successive Lok Sabhas. It passed the Rajya Sabha in 2010 but never came to a vote in the Lok Sabha.

The 2023 Act was supposed to end that wait. Instead, it has extended it. If delimitation is completed in 2032 or 2033, reservation will apply only from the 2034 general election. Women who celebrated the Act's passage in 2023 will wait through another full election cycle before they can contest a single reserved seat.

By tying women's representation to delimitation, the Act has entangled gender justice with India's most divisive demographic issue: the north-south seat distribution imbalance. When delimitation occurs, States with faster population growth will demand significantly more parliamentary seats. States that invested in population control will see their proportional representation decline. This tension is precisely why delimitation was frozen in 1976 and extended in 2001. By linking women's reservation to this unresolved federal arithmetic, Parliament has placed women's rights hostage to a debate that has paralysed consensus for half a century. This deadlock could further delay delimitation – and with it, women's reservation.

Why should half of India's citizens wait for an exercise that has nothing to do with gender equality? The constitutional timeline is not the only problem. The Act leaves critical design questions unanswered.

First, why does reservation exclude the Rajya Sabha and State Legislative Councils? The Act applies only to directly elected lower houses.

To tie the Women's Reservation Act – a constitutional promise – to delimitation fails India's women

India's leap, from back office to global brain trust

The narrative of India as the 'world's back office' has been officially retired. By early 2026, a profound transformation had occurred. India has become a strategic-nerve-centre for the global corporate elite. What were once known as captive centres are now Global Capability Centres (GCCs), which are sophisticated hubs that do not merely support the parent company but also define its future. This transition from cost-cutting centres to global growth engines marks a watershed moment in India's economic history.

The evolution of Indian GCCs has progressed through four distinct waves, culminating in the current GCC 4.0 era. Initially, centres were established to exploit labour arbitrage and handle routine IT and business process tasks. However, in the last few years, there has been a decisive move toward end-to-end product ownership.

Today, nearly 58% of GCCs in India are investing heavily in Agentic AI, which are autonomous Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems that can reason and execute complex tasks, thereby moving beyond mere experimentation to enterprise-scale deployment. These centres now manage global strategy leadership, high-end research and development (R&D), and proprietary intellectual property (IP) creation, making them indispensable nodes in the global value chain.

Benefits for companies and the nation

For multinational corporations (MNCs), the Indian GCC offers a unique competitive advantage: access to a multi-dimensional talent pool at a scale found nowhere else. With India housing over 1,800 GCCs and employing nearly two million professionals, companies can now drive faster innovation cycles through a follow-the-sun model. Beyond technology, these centres have become global "Centres of Excellence" (CoEs) for finance, legal, and human resources, allowing parent companies to centralise their most critical functions in a high-skill, high-efficiency environment.

Today, Indian GCCs act as global CoEs that



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is the Head of India at Sernova Financial

India's Global Capability Centre revolution is drawing eyeballs, but there are challenges as talent gaps, cyber threats and fiscal pressures

drive high-end R&D in fields such as quantum computing, semiconductor design, and Agentic AI. These centres no longer support the parent company. They have end-to-end product lifecycles, from initial conceptualisation and architecture to global deployment and customer feedback loops. This evolution means that the shadow leadership housed in Indian GCCs often possesses greater technical depth and execution power than the traditional headquarters.

For the Indian population, the GCC boom has catalysed high-value employment and regional development. These roles are intellectually stimulating and offer compensation far above that of traditional service-sector jobs, creating a new class of global professionals. Perhaps, most significantly, growth is finally trickling down into Tier-II and Tier-III cities such as Coimbatore (Tamil Nadu), Indore (Madhya Pradesh), and Kochi (Kerala). This geographic diversification reduces the strain on saturated metros such as Bengaluru and Hyderabad while stimulating local real estate, infrastructure, and retail economies across India.

Steering through challenges

Despite the record growth, the GCC ecosystem faces challenges that could threaten its momentum. The primary risk is the widening of the talent gap. Although India produces millions of engineers, the demand for niche skills in AI security, cloud architecture and quantum-resistant cryptography vastly outstrips the supply. This has triggered a fierce war for talent, leading to wage inflation that could eventually erode the value proposition of multinational corporations (MNC).

Furthermore, GCCs hold more critical global data and have become prime targets for state-sponsored cyber-attacks. With the implementation of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, the pressure on GCCs to maintain flawless cybersecurity governance has reached unprecedented levels. Simultaneously, the introduction of the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development's

Second, the Act provides no sub-reservation for Other Backward Class (OBC) women, even though Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe women receive proportional sub-quotas. OBC women constitute nearly 40% of India's female population.

Third, the Act mandates that reserved constituencies will rotate after each general election but offers no operational clarity. Will women candidates shift constituencies every five years? How will rotation work when delimitation itself reshuffles boundaries?

These unanswered questions compound the implementation crisis. Without clear rules, political parties will exploit ambiguities, legal challenges will multiply, and women candidates will bear the costs.

A straightforward solution

The constitutional barrier is real, but not inevitable. Parliament created it; Parliament can remove it.

There is no constitutional necessity tying women's reservation to delimitation. Article 15(3) already empowers the State to make "special provisions" for women and children. Parliament can exercise that power again to enable immediate implementation.

The solution is straightforward: amend the Constitution to permit reservation before delimitation, either by modestly expanding the Lok Sabha immediately or by applying reservation within current constituencies for two election cycles.

Alternatively, Parliament could expand the House incrementally – adding 180 seats earmarked exclusively for women – before full delimitation concludes. This would deliver on the reservation promise while avoiding displacement of incumbents.

None of these approaches is technically impossible. What is required is political will.

The government must clarify its road map now. Will it delink reservation from delimitation through amendment? Will it expand the Lok Sabha preemptively? Will it freeze State-wise seat allocation to prevent the north-south debate from derailing women's representation?

Parliament must also address the design gaps: extend reservation to the Upper Houses, include OBC sub-reservation, and publish clear rotation rules developed in consultation with women's organisations and constitutional experts.

Above all, Parliament must recognise one principle: representation delayed is representation denied.

India cannot afford another historic law that waits endlessly to take effect. If reservation is a constitutional promise – and the 2023 Act declares that it is – then it must now become a constitutional reality. Not in 2034. Not after another election cycle. Now.

India's women have waited long enough.

Global Minimum Tax (Pillar Two) fundamentally alters the tax arbitrage benefit that many MNCs previously enjoyed. With a global floor of 15% tax and the continued bone of contention regarding India's 24% markup for software R&D under Safe Harbour rules, fiscal predictability has become a top-tier board concern.

Finally, geopolitical volatility and protectionism pose long-term risks to investment. As of early 2026, global trade professionals are increasingly wary of United States tariff volatility and reshoring policies that encourage MNCs to return critical data operations to their home markets.

While India remains an attractive destination, owing to its scale, any shift toward digital sovereignty in western nations could slow the pace of new GCC setups. Additionally, as India-based centres now handle 13.7% of global cyber-attack incidents (Cyfirma Report, 2023), the threat of state-sponsored espionage and intellectual property theft has made cybersecurity the most expensive operational mandate for modern GCCs.

Need for proactive policymaking

To secure India's position as the world's innovation capital, policymakers must transition from regulators to active facilitators. The National GCC Policy Framework, proposed in the 2026-27 Budget cycle, is a step in the right direction, but execution is the key. The government should introduce a "Single-Window Clearance" system specifically for GCCs to streamline the establishment of legal entities. Additionally, rationalising transfer pricing norms and providing tax safe harbours for R&D-intensive operations will provide the fiscal certainty that global boards demand. By fostering deeper industry-academia collaborations to upskill the workforce in deep tech and offering capital subsidies for Tier-II expansion, India can ensure that its GCC revolution remains sustainable for the next decade.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Court versus Trump
The Supreme Court of the U.S. rejecting U.S. President Donald Trump's sweeping tariffs is a reflection of how elected governments take laws for granted. It is time that Mr. Trump respects federal laws and behaves

like a President of the American people, not as a sole leader of the world.
Prabhu Raj R.,
Bengaluru

The Nilgiris under siege
The sweeping land changes in the Nilgiris (Tamil Nadu,

"Hollowing out the hills", February 22, 2026) highlight not merely an environmental story but also one of governance failure hiding in plain sight. Estates are now vanishing with builders exploiting regulatory loopholes. When

recharge areas are paved over and shola patches replaced by concrete, the downstream consequences for Coimbatore, Tiruppur and Erode are not speculative but inevitable. The solution demands more than satellite monitoring or

belated notices. A meaningful Minimum Support Price for tea, strict enforcement of the Tamil Nadu Land Reforms Act, and community-level awareness can avert small tea estate distress sales. The Blue Mountains cannot

afford to wait for the Madras High Court to act alone.
K. Chidanand Kumar,
Bengaluru

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address.

Cricket goes on, no accountability yet

The RCB, the event managers who were part of the victory celebrations, and the KSCA were all booked in the stampede case. Hearing petitions filed by them challenging the FIR, the High Court of Karnataka restrained the State police from filing a chargesheet in the case without their prior permission. No chargesheet has been filed yet. The five police officers suspended over the stampede have all been reinstated. As life moves on, cricket resumes with another IPL season. The families of the 11 who died in the stampede, however, still await justice.

A new CPI base, a clearer inflation signal

A revised basket

State	Percentage (%)
Telangana	4.92
Kerala	3.67
Tamil Nadu	3.36
Rajasthan	3.17
Karnataka	2.99

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

PM suggests cleanliness as part of study

Making the road safe for pedestrians

Vienna, Feb. 21: A new contrivance to prevent a motor car from running over pedestrians was demonstrated to the Press by its inventor Jakob Singer. It consists of network of India rubber ropes as wide as the car and fixed in front of it. The Police forbade experiments with living persons, so a wooden image was weighted with iron to 120 pounds with movable limbs and this was at first used successfully. Subsequently a workman obligingly allowed himself to be run down and was caught in the net.

From Page One

Time for nations facing tariffs to unionise: Lula



Brazilian President Lula speaks at the India-Brazil Economic Forum in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

Mr. Lula also called for UN Security Council reforms, and in particular, seats in the Council for India, Brazil, and others.

“Why is India not a permanent member of the UN Security Council, a country that has 1.4 billion people? Why Brazil is not there at the UN Security Council,” he said, adding others such as Germany, Mexico, Nigeria and Egypt as well to the list. He said that as a result, the UN today does not have much efficacy. “UN is capable of making a diagnosis but it doesn’t have the capability to prescribe medication or do the treatment,” he said.

He said India had taught him some lessons in economic management, recounting a story from his visit to India in 2005, during his previous tenure as President, when he was hosted by then Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.

“It was in India in 2005 that, for the very first time, I perceived the importance of having international hard currency reserves,” he said, adding that he was impressed that India had then amassed \$100 billion in reserves. He said he had committed to do the same in Brazil, eventually building reserves of \$360 billion and Brazil moved from being a debtor to the IMF to a creditor, which he called a “transformative experience” for Brazil.

Mr. Lula recounted some personal memories as well, while speaking about his talks in Delhi which ended with agreements on critical mineral cooperation, steel mining and digital partnership. He said that he was touched that his favourite Brazilian songs were played during the official banquet lunch with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the dinner hosted by President Droupadi Murmu.

Three Jem terrorists killed in Kishtwar: Army

The Army said the forces displayed “tactical precision, seamless synergy and resolute aggression” during the gunfight, and the troops dominated the encounter site. “War-like stores, including two AK-47 rifles, have also been recovered,” the Army said.

General Upendra Dwivedi, Chief of the Army Staff, commended the troops of the Northern Command for “exemplary professionalism and steadfast resolve” in the ongoing counter-terror operations in Jammu and Kashmir, an Army spokesperson said. He lauded their vigilance, operational excellence and seamless coordination under challenging conditions.

The Army said that it “remains unwavering in its commitment to ensuring lasting peace in J&K with zero tolerance for terrorism in all its forms.”

Sunday’s encounter was part of Operation Trashi-I, which was launched in January against terrorists active in Kishtwar’s Chatroo belt. “Troops of White Knight Corps, along with J&K Police and CRPF, in a joint operation, established contact with terrorists,” the Army said.

There have been four major gunfights in the Kishtwar district this year. One soldier was killed on January 18, and a terrorist was gunned down on February 4 in two separate encounters in the district, which has many of J&K’s high mountain passes.

Amid SIR push, Calcutta HC forms panel to manage cases

Chief Justice Sujoy Paul meets Chief Electoral Officer, senior officials; following Supreme Court order, judicial officers are set to begin the process of completing the SIR in West Bengal today

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The Chief Justice of the Calcutta High Court, Sujoy Paul, has constituted a committee to oversee interim arrangements for shifting urgent matters to alternative courts, following the engagement of judicial officers for work related to the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in West Bengal.

The development comes in the wake of the Supreme Court’s order of February 20, in which it has directed that judicial officers be assigned to complete the ongoing SIR in West Bengal.

The top court pointed out that the persistent “trust deficit” between the State government led by Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and the Election Commission had led to a “stalemate”, with time running out.

The committee appointed by Chief Justice Paul comprises Justices Tapa-brata Chakraborty and Arijit Banerjee, Registrar General Nabanita Ray,



Paper trail: People wait in queues during hearings under the special intensive revision of electoral rolls, at Krishnanagar in Nadia district of West Bengal. PTI

Registrar (judicial service) Raju Mukherjee, and Joint Registrar-cum-Secretary to the Chief Justice Ajay Kumar Das.

District committees

In a separate notification, the Chief Justice of the Calcutta High Court constituted a committee for each district “for the smooth compliance of the order of the Hon’ble Supreme Court”, comprising the District Judge, the District Magistrate, and the Supe-

rintendent of Police.

On Sunday, Chief Justice Paul held a meeting with the State’s Chief Electoral Officer, Manoj Kumar Agarwal, Chief Secretary Nandini Chakravorty, Director-General of Police Piyush Pandey, Kolkata Commissioner of Police Supratim Sarkar, and other officials representing the Union of India.

It was decided that judicial officers would begin the process of completing the SIR from Monday. The Supreme Court had on February 20 also directed the EC to publish the processed list of electoral rolls on February 28.

Unless the electoral rolls are finalised, the schedule for the Assembly election in West Bengal cannot be announced.

The EC has decided to deploy 480 companies of the Central Armed Police Forces in the State by March 10. The first 240 companies will be deployed by March 1.

ED identifies eight priority areas for coordinated action

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate has identified eight focus areas for coordinated action. They are tracking of foreign assets, misuse of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, trade-based money laundering, cyber-fraud, illegal online gambling, drug financing, share market manipulation, and foreign interference through illicit funding.

The decision was taken during its 34th quarterly conference of zonal officers in Guwahati from February 19 to 21, headed by ED Director Rahul Navin.

All zonal heads were directed to intensify efforts in tracing and securing proceeds of crime parked abroad, particularly in jurisdictions such as Dubai and Singapore.

They were also told to keep a close watch on professional money laundering channels disguised as trade.

“Instances of potential collusion between corporate debtors, resolution professionals, members of the Committee of Creditors, and other stakeholders were flagged as areas requiring scrutiny,” said the agency with respect to IBC-related cases.

Given the rise in digital-arrest scams and other forms of cyberfraud, the ED chief asked officials to crack down on organised syndicates and identify cross-border elements. In cases involving illegal betting and online gaming platforms, they were advised to focus on dismantling the linked financial networks, including payment gateways, mule accounts and offshore operators.

Drug traffickers

The ED will also intensify action against the financial networks of drug traffickers and their “hawala” linkages, money laundering through share market manipulation, and foreign funding channels that may be used for unlawful narrative building, destabilising activities or other anti-national purposes. “The importance of international cooperation and development of institutional soft power was also highlighted, with emphasis on the ED being a reliable, professional and proactive partner for foreign counterpart agencies,” the ED said.

Before death, Manipur MLA wrote to PM, sought probe into mob attack

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Five months before his death, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MLA from Manipur Vungzagin Valte wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi detailing how he was brutally attacked by the “Meitei militia [Arambai Tenggol]”.

Valte had said that the attack left him with severe injuries that paralysed him, and despite the gravity of the incident, no special inquiry, either by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) or the National Investigation Agency (NIA), was ever initiated.

The letter was sent on September 13, 2025, when Mr. Modi made his maiden visit to Manipur after the ethnic violence broke out on May 3, 2023. Arambai Tenggol, a relatively new radical Meitei armed group, gained notoriety after the conflict between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities started.



Vungzagin Valte

Valte, who never recovered from the life-threatening injuries after being assaulted by a mob on May 4, 2023, passed away at a private hospital in Gurugram, Haryana, on Friday. “The arrest may take time as he was attacked by a mob. We are pursuing all leads,” Losii Dikho, Deputy Chief Minister, Manipur told *The Hindu*.

In the letter, Valte had said that as a three-term MLA and BJP adviser to former Chief Minister N. Biren Singh, he had “witnessed firsthand the challenges faced by the Zomi-Kuki-Hmar community”.

“On May 4, 2023, after attending security meeting at CM’s office, to discuss the safe transportation of my people especially Churachandpurians stranded in Imphal due to the ethnic violence, I was brutally attacked on my way back home at RIMS Road by the Meitei militia [Arambai Tenggol], resulting in severe injuries that have left me paralysed and handicapped till date. Despite the gravity of this incident, no special inquiry [CBI/NIA] has been initiated, and the community remains marginalised,” the letter said.

He added that the Zomi-Kuki-Hmar community had been driven out of the State capital Imphal and from the valley, leading to complete physical and social divide. “In light of this, I humbly request that a Separate Administration, preferably a Union Territory with a legislature under the Indian Constitution, be granted to the indigenous tribal community as mentioned above,” the letter said.

‘Lasting solution’

Valte had said that a separate administration would ensure justice, administrative convenience, and a lasting solution. He had said that his appeal aligned with the demands of the Kuki National Organisation and the United People’s Front, who are seeking a political solution through Suspension of Operations talks. “I urge you to consider this request at the highest level, as forced imposition of peace has proven unsustainable in Manipur’s history,” his letter said.

On the fateful day, when Valte was going to his official residence at Lamphelpat in Imphal, his car was stopped by a group of people. He and his driver, Thanghoulal, were physically assaulted.

Looking forward to Israel visit, says Modi

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said he was looking forward to his upcoming visit to Israel.

Mr. Modi said this on X in response to Israel’s Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s comment.

“Thank you, my friend... I fully agree with you on the bond between India and Israel as well as the diverse nature of our bilateral relations. India deeply values the enduring friendship with Israel, built on trust, innovation and a shared commitment to peace and progress. Looking forward to our discussions during my upcoming Israel visit,” Mr. Modi said.

Modi’s visit entangled in Israel’s turbulent domestic politics

Press Trust of India
JERUSALEM

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s upcoming Israel visit is getting entangled in the domestic politics of the West Asian country, with Opposition leader Yair Lapid threatening to boycott his parliamentary address unless the Supreme Court chief is invited for it, as per convention.

Mr. Modi is expected to arrive in Israel on Wednesday, for a two-day visit, during which he is likely to address the Knesset (Israeli parliament) and meet Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and President Isaac Herzog.

Mr. Lapid has insisted that Supreme Court President Yitzhak Amit be invited to the Knesset when Mr. Modi addresses the House. Sources in the Opposition maintain that it is not a call

for a boycott; instead, the government is “intentionally trying to force us into a bad situation”. “We spoke to the Indian embassy ... They are in panic from this. Prime Minister of India, Modi, is invited to the Knesset next Wednesday, something that is a matter of honour for all of us,” Mr. Lapid told the Knesset recently.

Internal turmoil

Israel’s domestic politics is embroiled in a heated debate over judicial overhaul, a divisive issue that has also sharply split the population for over two years. The country faced large protests on the issue before the October 7 attack by Hamas two years ago, drawing hundreds of thousands of people to the streets every weekend for almost 10 months.

Following Mr. Amit’s



Prime Minister Narendra Modi is likely to address the Knesset and meet his Israeli counterpart Benjamin Netanyahu during the visit.

election as court President in January 2025, Justice Minister Yariv Levin has refused to recognise his authority, meet him or address him as head of the court. The State Gazette has also not published his name as the Chief Justice, as required by law.

This has led to Mr. Amit’s exclusion from multiple Knesset events – including addresses by U.S. President Donald Trump and other world leaders – to which he would have traditionally been invited.

Two weeks ago, the Opposition boycotted a Knesset session to celebrate its 77th anniversary due to Mr. Amit’s exclusion.

“If the coalition boycotts the President of the top court during the special

session with the Prime Minister of India, we will not be able to attend the debate,” Mr. Lapid recently told the lawmakers, stressing that another public boycott of Mr. Amit by the coalition would cause “enormous embarrassment” to the legislature.

“We do not want India to be embarrassed by us, with the Prime Minister of a nation of a billion people standing here in front of a half-empty Knesset,” Mr. Lapid emphasised.

To prevent harm to ties between Jerusalem and New Delhi, Mr. Netanyahu “must immediately instruct Knesset Speaker Amir Ohana to also invite Supreme Court President Yitzhak Amit to the ceremonial meeting with Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi,” Mr. Lapid asserted.

The Opposition leader’s

threat has led to heated exchanges in the political circles with the Knesset Speaker accusing Mr. Lapid of harming the Indo-Israel relations in order to score domestic political points.

“If the Leader of the Opposition wants to harm the foreign relations of the State of Israel with an important friend of ours..., that is his choice. An unfortunate, wrong choice, and I hope he will reverse it,” Mr. Ohana posted on X, calling such threats “illegitimate weapons in an internal political struggle.”

The Speaker also called upon the Opposition leader to explain to the Indian government why he did not choose to boycott appearances by Argentinian President Javier Milei and Mr. Trump, “even though Justice Amit was not invited” to their speeches.

Student shot at outside BHU hostel, case filed

The Hindu Bureau
LUCKNOW

Gunshots were allegedly fired at a student outside the Birla hostel at Banaras Hindu University (BHU), officials said on Sunday. Roshan Mishra, a third-year BA student, claimed three persons arrived on a motorcycle and suddenly opened fire when he was standing outside the hostel on Saturday night. No one was injured in the incident.

“We have registered a case against five individuals... and efforts are under way to catch them,” said the police.

The police believed the alleged incident is the result of a rivalry between two students’ groups.

BSP seeking ‘master key of power’, says Mayawati

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) will continue striving to obtain the “master key of power” through democratic means, party chief Mayawati said on Sunday while chairing an all-India meeting of the party at its central camp office in Lucknow to review organisational strengthening across the country.

Taking note of concerns in the country over trade deals with various nations and blocs – especially the interim deal with the U.S. – Ms. Mayawati said the cut-throat competition among countries to “make themselves first” had pushed the exploitative global order into a deeper crisis.

Alleging that policies of rival parties have undermined their credibility, she said the BSP’s governance record in Uttar Pradesh, based on ‘*Sarvajan Hitay, Sarvajan Sukhay*’ (welfare of all, happiness of all) and the rule of law, had raised expectations among the public.

She also praised party workers for their efforts despite alleged obstacles from rival parties and governments.

Congress protest shows its ideological bankruptcy: PM

Modi accuses party of using AI Impact Summit for ‘dirty and shameless politics’; he says Congress should have taken into account the fact that it was not a BJP or NDA event, but a national event

The Hindu Bureau
GHAZIABAD

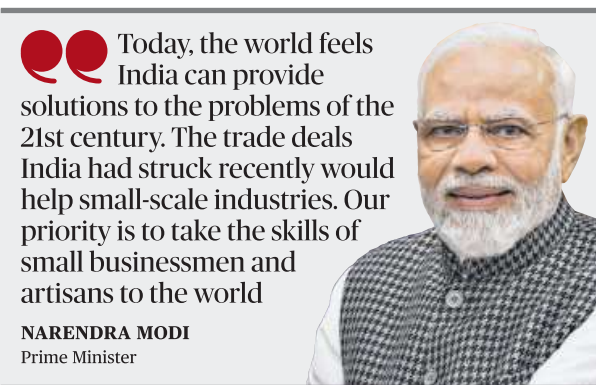
In a scathing attack on the Congress, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday accused the principal Opposition party of indulging in “dirty and shameless politics”.

Linking the party youth wing’s “shirtless” protest on Friday at the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi to the nation’s image, Mr. Modi said the Congress and its ecosystem had touched a new low.

Describing the topless protest as “*nangi rajneeti*” (naked politics) in front of industry leaders, he said it was an example of ideological bankruptcy that had lowered the dignity of a global event.

“Everybody knows you [Congress] are naked. You don’t need to take off clothes,” Mr. Modi said, addressing a public meeting in Meerut on the sidelines of the inauguration of the Namo Bharat Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) and Meerut Metro.

Separating the Congress from the rest of the Oppo-



sition, the Prime Minister said even the Congress’s allies had deserted it on the issue.

‘Just the Congress’

Mr. Modi asked the media not to generalise his criticism of the Congress as that of the entire Opposition. “Were the TMC (Trinamool Congress), DMK (Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam), BSP (Bahujan Samaj Party), or NC (National Conference) responsible for the Delhi protest? No, it was just the Congress that sinned, and I want to publicly pay gratitude to those who have criticised the Congress’s behaviour,” he said.

Reiterating that the Congress leadership hated him and wanted to dig his grave, Mr. Modi said they should have taken into account that the summit was not a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) or National Democratic Alliance (NDA) event.

“It was a national event, the first of its kind organised in a developing country to take a leadership role in the 21st century,” the Prime Minister said.

A pattern

Describing it as a pattern, Mr. Modi, for the first time, reacted to Speaker Om Birla’s apprehension over the picketing of his (Mr. Mo-

di’s) Lok Sabha seat by female Congress MPs.

“One has to win hearts to become PM. One can’t become PM by sending female MPs to surround the PM’s chair. What’s the compulsion? Are you that hollow?” the Prime Minister said, targeting the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi.

Eager for trade

Referring to the recent trade agreements with the European Union and the United States, Mr. Modi said the developed world was eager to trade with India.

“It was not the case during the Congress rule because of its scam-tainted image. Today, the world feels India can provide solutions to the problems of the 21st century,” Mr. Modi said.

The trade deals India had struck recently would help small-scale and cottage industries, he said. “Our priority is to take the entrepreneurship and skills of small businessmen and artisans to the world,” he added.

Prime Minister launches full Delhi-Meerut RRTS corridor

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday inaugurated the remaining sections of the Namo Bharat Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS), including the 5-km stretch between Sarai Kale Khan and New Ashok Nagar in Delhi and the 21-km stretch between Meerut South and Modipuram in Uttar Pradesh. The RRTS has been integrated with the Meerut Metro, which was also launched.

Mr. Modi said the entire 82-km corridor of the RRTS project provided a glimpse of what connectivity would look like in a developed India that used Metro rail for intra-city travel and the Namo Bharat trains to accelerate the “twin cities” vision. “This integration allows commuters to travel within the city or go directly to Delhi, thus ending the compulsion for many workers and students to live in rented houses in Delhi. A unique feature of the project is the integration of Indian Railways, Metro, and bus stands at Sarai Kale Khan, Anand Vihar, Ghaziabad, and Meerut,” he said.

Talking about development in the regions, Mr. Modi said, “The govern-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi waves to the gathering during the launch of the Meerut Metro and Namo Bharat services. PTI

ment’s investment in modern infrastructure, including expressways, freight corridors, and the Jewar International Airport is creating vast employment opportunities.”

Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal, speaking at the inauguration, said the proposal for two new rapid rail corridors starting from Sarai Kale Khan was expected to be approved soon.

“One corridor is planned from Sarai Kale Khan to Karnal in Haryana, covering a distance of 125-130 km, which can be completed in about an hour and a half. Another route is proposed to connect Sarai Kale Khan with Babarpur in Haryana and Neemrana in Rajasthan,” he said.

The Sarai Kale Khan station, the originating station of the corridor, is strategically located as a major multi-modal hub, seamlessly connecting the Hazrat Nizamuddin railway station, Delhi Metro’s Pink Line, Veer Haqueqat Rai ISBT, and Ring Road.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, commenting on the launch, said the Delhi-Meerut corridor will transform the capital’s pace of development and stimulate economic activity in the Delhi-NCR region. “The corridor will help passengers save time and resources, marking a historic milestone for Delhi and the surrounding region as the project is expected to ease traffic congestion and reduce carbon emissions by reducing the number of private vehicles on the roads, thereby creating a positive environmental impact,” she said.

Congress rebuts PM, says women MPs were protesting for a cause

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Sunday reacted sharply to Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s statement that “one can’t become Prime Minister by sending women MPs to capture the Lok Sabha seat”. Mr. Modi made the comments at a public event after inaugurating the Delhi-Meerut Rapid Rail Transit System.

“It is very unfortunate that Prime Minister forgets that Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi ji was not allowed to speak during the Motion of Thanks

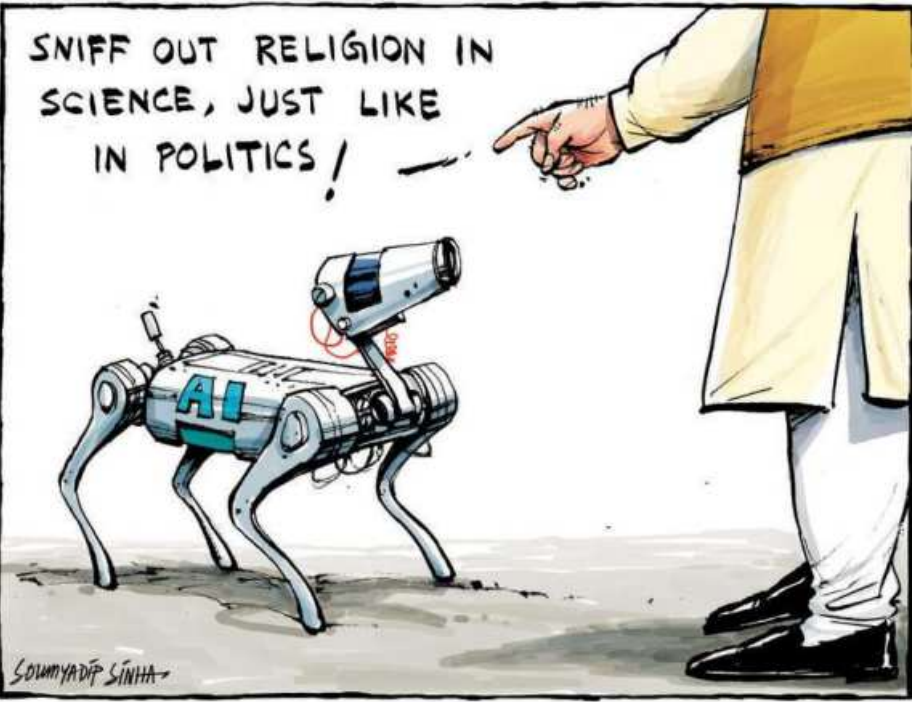
to the President’s Address. For two days, Mr. Gandhi was not allowed to speak in Lok Sabha. Then, eight of us were suspended. Only then women MPs protested,” Congress Whip in the Lok Sabha Manickam Tagore said in a video posted on X. “You were afraid to come to the House, Mr. Prime Minister. It is not as if the women MPs, who belong to Dalit and backward classes, were misbehaving, they were protesting for a cause,” he added.

The Prime Minister had “compromised the interest of farmers, MSMEs (micro, small and medium enter-

prises) and textile industry” through the India-U.S. trade agreement over which Indian Youth Congress workers protested at the recent AI Impact Summit, Mr. Tagore said.

Former IYC chief Srinivas B.V. also defended the IYC’s “shirtless protests”, and accused the Prime Minister of playing the “victim card”. “Did IYC claim the Chinese [robot] dog as Indian? Did IYC get stalls for fraud institutions like Galgotia? Did IYC sign an anti-India trade deal? Did IYC’s name come up in the Epstein files?” Mr. Srinivas said in a post on X.

On the draw



AI Impact Summit is a ‘turning point’ in use of tech: Modi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The India AI Impact Summit “proved to be a turning point in the trajectory of how the world will utilise the power of AI in the future”, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Sunday, adding that global leaders were impressed by India’s progress in the domain.

In his *Mann ki Baat* address, Mr. Modi – who met global leaders and tech CEOs and showed them India’s innovations – said leaders from many countries and industries, innovators, and people from the start-up sector came together at the summit.

Eighty-five countries and three international organisations signed the New Delhi Declaration. “Guided by the principle of ‘*Sarvajan Hitaya, Sarvajan Sukhaya*’ [Welfare for all, Happiness for all], the Declaration underscores that the benefits of AI must be equitably shared across humanity,” the government had said.

Mr. Modi said world leaders were impressed by two exhibits at the venue. The first one showed how use of AI helped people in the treatment of animals, and how farmers tracked their livestock with 24x7 assistance.

The second was related to Indian culture and heritage. Mr. Modi said leaders were amazed at how with the help of AI, India is preserving ancient texts, knowledge, manuscripts.

The AI summit, which ended in Delhi on Friday, attracted five lakh visitors.

Lyutens’s statue to be replaced by Rajagopalachari’s

Ahead of the ‘Rajaji Utsav’ celebration on Monday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Sunday that a statue of British architect Edwin Lutyens in Rashtrapati Bhavan will be replaced by that of C. Rajagopalachari, the first Indian Governor-General of independent India.

Mr. Modi urged people to remain vigilant against online financial fraud and digital arrests. He appealed for complete KYC compliance saying it is crucial for the safety of an individual’s bank account.

In the backdrop of the Opposition’s allegations that the India had compromised the interests of farmers during trade negotiations with the U.S., he said farmers were not just food providers, but true “devotees” of the earth. He highlighted how farmers are blending tradition with technology and cited the example of Hirod Patel in Odisha who has installed a mesh over a pond and is growing vegetables on it. He said in Kerala’s Thrissur, 570 varieties of rice are grown in a single field.

“Today, India has become the world’s largest rice producer... agricultural products are now reaching foreign countries more easily by air. Nanjangud bananas from Karnataka, Mysuru betel leaves, and Indli lemons were exported to the Maldives,” he said.

Former Assam Cong. president Bhupen Borah joins BJP

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Former Assam Congress president Bhupen Kumar Borah joined the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday, a week after quitting the party he served for almost 33 years.

State BJP president and MP Dilip Saikia welcomed Mr. Borah, a two-time former MLA, at a programme organised at Vajpayee Bhavan, the party’s headquarters in Guwahati.

Soon after joining the party, Mr. Borah said any self-respecting Assamese would cease to stay with the Congress.

“The Congress has 700 ticket aspirants and 100 of them will be able to contest the Assembly election. The remaining 600 may not come to the BJP, but the self-respecting Assamese of Rajiv Bhavan (State Congress headquarters) will come to Vajpayee Bhavan,” he told presspersons.

He said the condition of many leaders in the Congress was like that of the Mahabharata’s Karna before he died.

“I have moved away



Bhupen Borah

from Duryodhana but the Karnas are still there. They will slowly get to know who will be on which side in the battle of the Mahabharata. I want to tell the Karnas of Rajiv Bhavan that the result of this battle has been already decided,” he said, pointing to the election to the 126-member Assembly expected in April.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma congratulated Mr. Borah for “beginning a new life from today”.

Mr. Borah resigned from the Congress on February 17 over differences with the State leadership. The party’s top leaders, including Rahul Gandhi, had asked him to consider withdrawing his resignation, but he remained unmoved.

Dismiss Piyush Goyal from Cabinet, SKM urges Murmu

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM) has sent a letter to President Droupadi Murmu on Sunday, urging her to dismiss Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal from his post for “betraying the nation’s confidence” by entering into a bilateral trade agreement with the United States. The SKM urged her to direct the Prime Minister not to sign the agreement on terms which were detrimental to farmers. It also sought a direction from her against a recent demi-official letter of the Union Finance Ministry asking the Kerala government to end bonus to paddy farmers.

The SKM alleged in the letter that the Narendra Modi government succumbed to the pressures of the U.S. and endangered India’s self-reliance and sovereignty. Maintaining that the terms accepted as per the interim deal were detrimental to the interests of the Indian economy and farmers, the SKM said the government remained silent about the terms. “In fact, all announcements made by Union Commerce



The withdrawal of 11% cotton import duty on August 19, 2025 has sunk domestic cotton prices, the SKM said. REUTERS

Minister Piyush Goyal, the chief negotiator, only confirm the worst fears, that the government is either unable to or unwilling to stand up to U.S. dictates. Such acquiescence before an imperial superpower has led to serious resentment among the farming community,” the letter said.

‘No satisfactory answer’

The SKM asked when no deal had been signed as of now, why did U.S. President Donald Trump declare the free trade agreement with India. “Why did Prime Minister Narendra Modi endorse India as a party to the agreement? Why no statement placed in Parliament that was in session? The Prime Minis-

ter has yet to give a satisfactory answer,” it said.

On cotton, the SKM said India was self-dependent with double the production of the U.S. “The withdrawal of 11% cotton import duty on August 19, 2025 has sunk domestic cotton prices. Cotton farmers are staring at very serious losses,” it said, adding that Mr. Goyal was insensitive to this issue. The SKM added that the deal would put over 55 lakh apple farmer families in the country into crisis. Maize would be imported as dry distilled grain (DDG) as per the interim deal and the import of DDG would deplete the domestic prices and impact 120 lakh corn farmers, the SKM maintained.

U.S. trade deal must be put in cold storage, says Congress

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Taking a swipe at the government over the interim U.S. trade deal, the Congress on Sunday said it was reflective of “*Abki baar Trump se haar*” and must be put in “cold storage” in view of the confusion following the U.S. Supreme Court’s verdict.

Congress general secretary communications in-charge Jairam Ramesh said the terms of the framework for the interim agreement must be renegotiated and the clause talking about import liberalisation, especially of agricultural produce, must be scrapped. Mr. Ramesh said an agreement was about give and take but India had only given under the deal.

“Prime Minister Narendra Modi had given a slogan in Houston in 2019 – ‘*Abki baar Trump Sarkaar*’ but this framework for an interim agreement is proof of ‘*Abki baar Trump se haar*’,” he said. What happened on February 2 that there was a need for the Prime Minister to “force” Mr. Trump to announce the trade deal, he asked.

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NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The APTRANSCO invites bids online for the following work with **Spec. No: PMMT2-e-10/2026**, **Name of the Work:** Supply, Erection / Stringing and Commissioning of OPGW cable and associated equipment under PSD funding for providing reliable communication system upto 132 kV substations in Six Lots. Date & Time of availability of Tender on e-procurement platform i.e., **www.tender.apeprocurement.gov.in** on **23.02.2026 @17:00 Hrs.** Contact No. **Dy.EE: 8332949383**,
Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER / TELECOM & IT
R.O. No.: **GMCC/APTRANSCO/53/26**

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Guaranteed return plan

Pavit LauI

A decade ago, Sanjay, a salaried professional, locked his savings in a fixed deposit (FD). Last month, when it matured, he realised it did not really translate into what he expected. First, the maturity amount, when adjusted for tax and inflation, did not stretch as far as he had imagined. Second, he realised on account of lower interest rates, renewing FD meant much reduced returns in future. The plan did not deliver the financial milestone he was hoping for.

This is the story of millions of savers who are discovering that in today's financial environment, safety alone is no longer enough. What people increasingly seek is not just protection of capital, but protection of purchasing power and long-term financial goals. And this is where guaranteed return plans are gaining relevance among new-age investors.

Certainty as financial priority
While the focus was on maximising returns a few years earlier, today, it is equally on ensuring consistency. This shift is driven by factors such as sliding interest rates, market volatility and high lifestyle inflation. In such an environment, certainty itself becomes valuable. Guaranteed return plans are built around delivering that certainty.

For decades, FDs served as the go-to option for investors who wished to play safe. However, they carry two structural limitations. First, FD interest is fully taxable, which reduces effective compounding over time. A seemingly competitive rate can translate into lower post-tax returns, especially over long horizons. Second, FDs expose investors to reinvestment risk. When FD matures, there is no certainty same rates will be available. This combination can gradually weaken long-term financial planning.

Guaranteed return plans
These plans are long-term insurance-linked savings products that combine wealth creation with life protection. The returns are fixed and assured at the time of purchase and once locked in, they are unchanged for the entire policy span. The returns are unaffected by market movements or interest-rate cycles.

This clarity allows people to plan life goals such as a child's education, retirement income or financial security for the family. Currently, many guaranteed return plans offer returns up to 6.9-7%. The real USP of these plans lie in predictability as the returns do not fluctuate.

Also, maturity proceeds qualify for tax exemption under Section 10(10D), provided the aggregate annual premium across eligible policies don't exceed ₹5 lakh. This helps preserve returns without tax erosion, boosting long-term compounding compared with fully-taxable instruments. Also, premiums paid qualify for deductions under Section 80C, which improves tax efficiency.

The compounding effect
Suppose A invests ₹24 lakh in a FD with 6% interest and Investor B the same amount in a guaranteed return plan offering 6.9% tax-free returns. At the end of 10 years, Investor A's corpus would be much lower than Investor B's even before maturity tax cut. And when you adjust for taxation, the effective amount reduces further. Basically, FD returns are added to the taxable income and taxed as per your income slab. So, for those in 30% tax slab, FD proceeds will also be taxed at 30%. Investor B's maturity value, by contrast, stays largely preserved.

Securing dependents
Another feature is the built-in life cover in these plans. Guaranteed return plans include an insurance component providing financial protection to dependents. This dual structure of savings plus protection ensures that long-term goals remain safeguarded even in unforeseen circumstances even in the policyholder's absence.
Guaranteed return plans are not for replacing other investments. Equity-based assets are crucial for long-term growth and inflation participation. However, guaranteed return plans serve the distinct role of anchoring a portfolio with predictability, tax efficiency and long-term certainty.
(The writer is Head, Investments, Policybazaar.com)



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

Opportunities, risks in porting health policy

The facility to shift a health insurance policy from one insurer to another was unveiled in end 2011 by insurance regulator opening up options for insured to better terms elsewhere

TO SHIFT OR NOT?

K. Nitya Kalyani

A few days ago in this column, we examined the risks some insureds encountered while attempting to port hospitalisation policies. After paying the premium, they found themselves either without cover for a period or saddled with terms materially different from what they had proposed and paid for.

In this context, let us look at how you can port policy smoothly –what advantages you should leverage, and the risks and mistakes you should avoid.

Portability – the facility to shift a hospitalisation insurance policy from one insurer to another – was unveiled in end 2011 by the insurance regulator, opening up options for insured to better terms elsewhere and nudge insurers to focus on customer retention via fair pricing and improved service.

No simple exercise
The inspiration was mobile number portability implemented earlier in 2011 giving consumers unprecedented freedom. However, insurance is a far more complex. Porting a health policy was never meant to be a simple “walk in with KYC and switch” exercise, as in the case of mobiles.

Why would you want to port the policy? Primarily, to access better products, get wider coverage or more suitable policy terms with another insurer. This could

In portability, the insurer has to carry forward key accrued benefits from existing policy – sum insured, no-claim bonus and credit built up towards completing waiting period for pre-existing diseases

mean broader risk cover, fewer restrictions, higher sum insured or more competitive pricing.

Equally crucial are service-related considerations – poor responsiveness, unsatisfactory TPA performance or an inadequate hospital network.

That said, porting is not a step to be taken lightly. Your new insurer has the right to accept/reject the proposal. Contrast this with your position with the existing insurer, who is obligated under norms to offer lifelong renewal, provided there is no fraud or material non-disclosure.

Portability does come with certain protections. The destination insurer has to carry forward key accrued benefits from the existing policy – sum insured, no-claim bonus and the credit built up towards completing waiting period for pre-existing diseases and specified treatments

The new insurer, however, is free to set its premium. This is often the very reason porting appears attractive. But as highlighted in the earlier article, it is crucial to ensure you have

Porting is likely s to be smoother if one is young or middle-aged and sans major pre-existing conditions. For insurer, he/she represents lower risk with many premium-paying years ahead of the insured

firm, final terms and rates before letting the existing policy lapse. If this clarity is missing, it is safer to renew with the current insurer – on known, even if imperfect, terms – and work on porting the next year.

A few decision-making pointers may help.

Porting tends to be smoother if you are young or middle-aged and do not have major pre-existing conditions. From an underwriting perspective, you represent a lower risk with many premium-paying years ahead, making acceptance more likely.

In such cases, porting can be a good opportunity to move to policies with better coverage, fewer sub-limits (such as on room rent) or more favourable pricing.

On the other hand, if the current insurer provided good service – prompt claim settlements, reliable TPA support – and you are close to completing waiting periods for pre-existing conditions, continuity itself has value. In such situations, porting may not be the optimal choice.

Instead, consider in-

creasing sum insured with the same insurer, or adding a top-up or super top-up policy. The options typically need no fresh medical underwriting, avoid unpleasant surprises and allow you to continue seamlessly with an insurer you already know. This approach also works well if you have employer-provided base cover and are building personal health insurance alongside it.

Retirement age
For those approaching or past retirement age, porting can be particularly risky. The outcomes may include outright rejection, sharply higher premiums, or additional exclusions and conditions. Staying with the existing insurer preserves the right to life-long renewability – a benefit that should not be underestimated in today's health cover landscape.

Here again, top-ups and super top-ups are efficient ways to expand coverage. When accepted, they offer a significantly lower premium per rupee of sum insured compared with a base policy.

Finally, remember this distinction: porting policy is your right, but underwriting remains the insurer's right. In the coming articles in this column, we will outline a practical game plan and decision matrix to help you navigate this process with clarity and confidence.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)

On alpha fade rate

THINKINVESTOR

Alpha fade rate refers to the gradual decay in the alpha strategy. This is because rate at which an alpha strategy fades can be faster than the rate at which a newer alpha strategy can be developed

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

We had discussed why popularity is not necessarily good (alpha scalability) when it comes to active fund investing. Now, look at a related characteristic viz. alpha fade rate.

Alpha decay
Alpha fade rate refers to the gradual decay in the alpha strategy. This happens because the rate at which an alpha strategy fades can be faster than the rate at which a newer alpha strategy can be developed. Why?
Alpha is the excess returns that a portfolio generates over its appropriate benchmark. An alpha strategy is a rule a portfolio manager applies to create a portfolio from the investable universe to generate positive alpha. Suppose a portfolio's investment universe is the 100 large-cap stocks. An alpha strategy can be a combination of fundamental factors such as profit margin, five-year sales growth and net profit growth of firms in the universe and technical factors such as each stock's price volatility and trading volumes. A portfolio manager and investment team will arrive at an optimal combination of these factors to help them generate alpha returns.

But why should alpha fade? Significant changes to market norms over the years reduced information asymmetry – market participants have access to the same company information. Using this information to test an alpha strategy is easy because of cheap computing power. This means a level-playing field among market participants, especially the institutional investors. Even if one portfolio manager beats the others to designing a new strategy, it may not be long before the others catch up. When many institutions follow the same strategy, it will eventually fade. Note, a strategy must be unique to be able to generate the alpha. Therein lies the problem.

Conclusion
Creating new alpha strategy may not be the issue. Rather, the problem is in applying the strategy to the same universe of stocks. Suppose a portfolio manager applies 10 factors to pick stocks and another applies a different set of factors. If both are large-cap managers, they will apply the rule to the same 100 stocks. So, it is highly likely both buy similar stocks, despite applying different set of rules. When a large cohort of managers take similar action, consistently generating alpha becomes difficult. This is true in markets such as the U.S., but emerging markets such as India may not be far behind. You must be mindful of this factor when you buy active funds.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals for managing their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Source:Paisabazaar.com				
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.10	6.35	7.10	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	7.20	6.90	7.00	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	7.60	4.75	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	7.77	7.00	7.50	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	7.50	6.00	6.75	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	7.90	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.45	7.25	7.20	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	7.50	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.20	7.00	7.00	5.85
City Union Bank	7.00	6.80	6.50	6.25
CSB Bank	7.00	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.60	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.15	6.90	7.00	7.15
Federal Bank	6.70	6.25	6.70	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.00	6.30	7.00	7.00
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	6.90	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.25	6.75	6.65	6.60
IDBI Bank	6.55	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	6.65	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.70	6.50	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.30	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.60	6.35	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.10	6.80	6.60	6.60
YES Bank	7.00	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.45	6.10	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.70	6.25	6.25	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.20	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.50	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.50	6.20	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.45	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.40	6.10	6.30	6.10
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.75	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.60	6.30	6.25	6.00
Rates as on Feb.17				

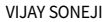
Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50
Punjab National Bank	7.25-9.10	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.10 #	7.10 #	7.10 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.70 #	7.70 #	7.70 #
ICICI Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.80 #	7.80 #	7.80 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68

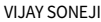
Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Federal Bank	7.50 - 9.50	7.50 - 9.50	7.50 - 9.50
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.05 #	8.05 #	8.05 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Tata Capital	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	10.00 #	10.00 #	10.00 #
Sammaan Capital	8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
*Extra rate cut of 0.05% to borrowers opting for insurance programmes for individuals for managing their personal investments			
Rates as on Feb.18 #onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com			

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We could have batted better, but it's part of the game: Suryakumar



India suffers its biggest loss by runs in T20 World Cup history



Some of us have played in India, but a majority haven't: Raza



Bennett's role is to bat as long as he can, says Zimbabwe skipper



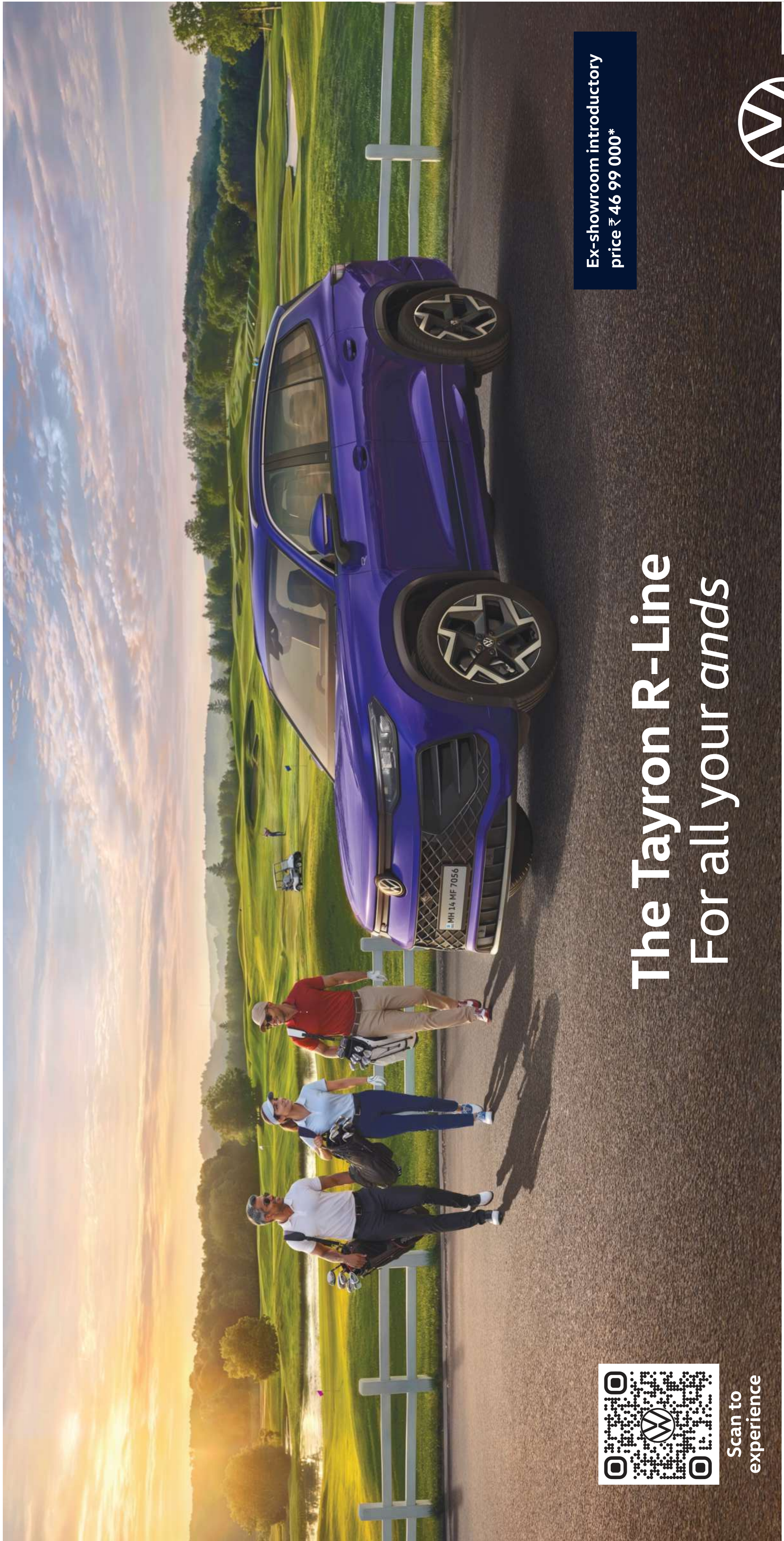
All-round Proteas bring Men in Blue crashing down

Putting on a show: Miller counterattacked before Stubbs cut loose at the death to take Proteas to a big total. Jansen was the wrecker-in-chief with four scalps. VIJAY SONEJI

Salt and Jacks star in England's comprehensive win over Lanka

West Indies meets Zimbabwe in a battle between high-flying teams

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Is badminton willing to trade depth for speed?

The proposal to replace the 3x21 scoring system with a 3x15 format will go to vote at BWF's Annual General Meeting in April; if adopted, it will reshape how the sport is played and the shuttlers are coached

GETTY IMAGES

Devvanshi Bihani

The Badminton World Federation's proposal to replace the long-standing 3x21 scoring system with a 3x15 format is being regarded as a forward-looking reform – one that promises shorter matches, greater excitement, and improved player welfare, according to the sport's governing body.

The BWF president Khunying Patama Leeswadtrakul described it as a move to ensure the sport “continues to grow, inspire, and thrive.” She argued that the format will make matches more dynamic and help badminton “stand out in an increasingly fast-paced entertainment landscape.” The proposal will go to vote at BWF's Annual General Meeting on April 25, but the direction of travel is already clear.

This is not merely a technical adjustment. It is a shift in the very grammar of badminton. How matches are constructed, how players win, and how the sport is experienced.

From endurance to immediacy

For nearly two decades, elite badminton has evolved into a sport of attrition. The 3x21 point system rewards not just skill, but patience, recovery, and the ability to navigate momentum swings over time.

The proposed format changes that balance. With fewer points in each game, there is less room for error and far less time to recover. A four or five-point run, which is routine in modern badminton, can become decisive. The emphasis shifts from managing the flow of a match to seizing early control.

This inherently favours fast starters who impose themselves quickly, attacking players capable of scoring bursts and strong serve-return exponents who can dictate early rallies. And it could be a disadvantage for defensive players who build pressure over time, tactical players who rely on mid-game adjustments and athletes who traditionally grow into matches.

In effect, the new system compresses matches into their most volatile phase – the closing stretch.

When matches get shorter...

Badminton's most memorable matches have rarely been about speed alone. They have been about how contests evolve – how players adapt, endure, and ultimately outthink and outlast their opponents.

Take the 2006 Malaysian Open final between era-defining rivals Lee Chong Wei and Lin Dan. Trailing 13-20 in the deciding game, Lee produced one of the most remarkable turnarounds in the sport's history by winning 10 consecutive points to clinch it 23-21.

Another case in point was the 2015 Japan Open final between Viktor Axelsen and Lin. The decider showed why Lin is often hailed as one of badminton's all-time greats. Trailing by a mile as Axelsen surged to an 11-3 lead at the interval, Lin mounted a stunning comeback, going on an 11-2 run to edge ahead 14-13.

The contest swung back and forth, with both players exchanging leads and relentless rallies until it was locked at

19-19. Lin held his nerve in the closing moments, taking the final two points to seal a thrilling victory. The Chinese was well past his physical peak and served a reminder that badminton is as much about intelligence as it is about intensity.

More recently, it was H.S. Prannoy's win over Koki Watanabe at the China Open last year. The Indian was down 15-20 in the deciding game before he shifted gears and saved five match points to win 23-21. It is considered a miracle win. A 50-shot rally near the end and an unshakable defence helped him save all match points. While this was a first-round match, Prannoy's comeback on a Super 1000 stage was widely praised given his age and recent struggles.

Players like Japan's Nozomi Okuhara have built success by sustaining pressure across long rallies, either through relentless defence or by forcing opponents into errors over time. One of the greatest women's singles matches ever played was the 2017 World Championships title decider between Okuhara and P.V. Sindhu. It lasted an hour and 50 minutes.

Okuhara's defence against the Indian's relentless attack created a match that ebbed and flowed, with neither player able to dominate for long. Okuhara could achieve victory only because the format allowed the match to stretch into a test of stamina and resilience. In the 3x15 system, that space to grind an opponent down is reduced.

Carolina Marin's victory at the 2019 China Open is another example. Returning from injury, she was initially down by a game and trailed 13-19 in the decider against Tai Tzu-ying. Yet, she fought back point by point, maintaining relentless pressure to turn the match around.

One can also revisit the 2015 World Championships quarterfinals and watch Indonesia's Lindaweni Fanetri. Down 14-20 in the second game after losing the opener, she saved multiple match points and reeled off eight straight points to force a decider, before closing out the match.

Doubles, already the fastest discipline,

could become even more volatile. With games to 15, there is little scope to recover from a poor service sequence or a brief lapse in concentration.

The 2019 World Championships men's doubles final between Mohammad Ahsan/Hendra Setiawan and Takuro Hoki/Yugo Kobayashi was a contest of experience against pace with the Indonesians' control emerging over time.

In the 2024 China Masters mixed doubles event, Malaysia's Chen Tang Jie and Toh Ee Wei were 11-20 down in the second game of a match. They saved all match points, winning 23-21, before carrying that momentum into the decider. It was a reminder that even the fastest discipline relies on momentum built over time.

These contests were compelling because they allowed time for strategies to emerge, for weaknesses to be exposed, and for players to respond. The 3x21 system allows a slow starter to recover, a defender to turn the match into an endurance test, and a trailing player to rebuild. The proposed system shortens that arc. It does not eliminate comebacks, but it might make them rarer. Because the space for adjustment narrows, and with it, the layers that define elite contests.

The Indian context

Sindhu's biggest victories, including her Olympic runs, have come from her ability to stay in rallies, absorb pressure, and grow into matches. Prannoy, too, has made a career out of comebacks.

K. Srikanth might not mind the change. At his peak, his game was based on pace and attacking precision. In theory, a shorter format could suit that style provided he can consistently start fast. Lakshya Sen may be one of the Indian players best placed to adapt. His ability to take the early initiative could prove valuable.

In doubles, the picture is unclear. India's leading pairs: Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, and Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand are capable of explosive starts but consistency remains a concern. There is little room to recover from lapses, and unforced errors

will carry greater consequences.

Yet, there is also an opportunity. Shorter matches reduce the physical gap between players. Nations that have historically relied and invested heavily in endurance training, notably China and Japan, may lose some of their structural advantage.

A sport shaped by television

For a sport increasingly conscious of broadcast windows and audience retention, the logic is understandable. It is impossible to separate this proposal from the broader pressures facing modern sport.

This is not the first time the BWF has attempted to alter the scoring system. Previous proposals were debated and rejected, after failing to secure sufficient support among stakeholders. What is different now is the framing. The system is being presented not as an experiment but as a strategic necessity tied to player welfare, broadcast viability, and the sport's long-term growth.

Badminton, like many Olympic sports, is competing for attention in a crowded entertainment landscape. Shorter matches are easier to schedule and broadcast, and more accessible to new audience.

But there is a trade-off. The push for brevity often comes at the expense of complexity. Sports that compress their formats risk losing the very elements that made them distinctive.

In badminton's case, that distinctiveness lies in its ability to combine speed with endurance, precision with patience. It is one of the few sports where rallies can be both explosive and prolonged, where matches can swing dramatically over time. Reducing the length of games risks tilting that balance too far in one direction.

If the new system is adopted, it will reshape how badminton is played and the shuttlers are coached. Training methods will evolve. Tactical approaches will shift. The next generation of players will grow up in a different game.

THE GIST

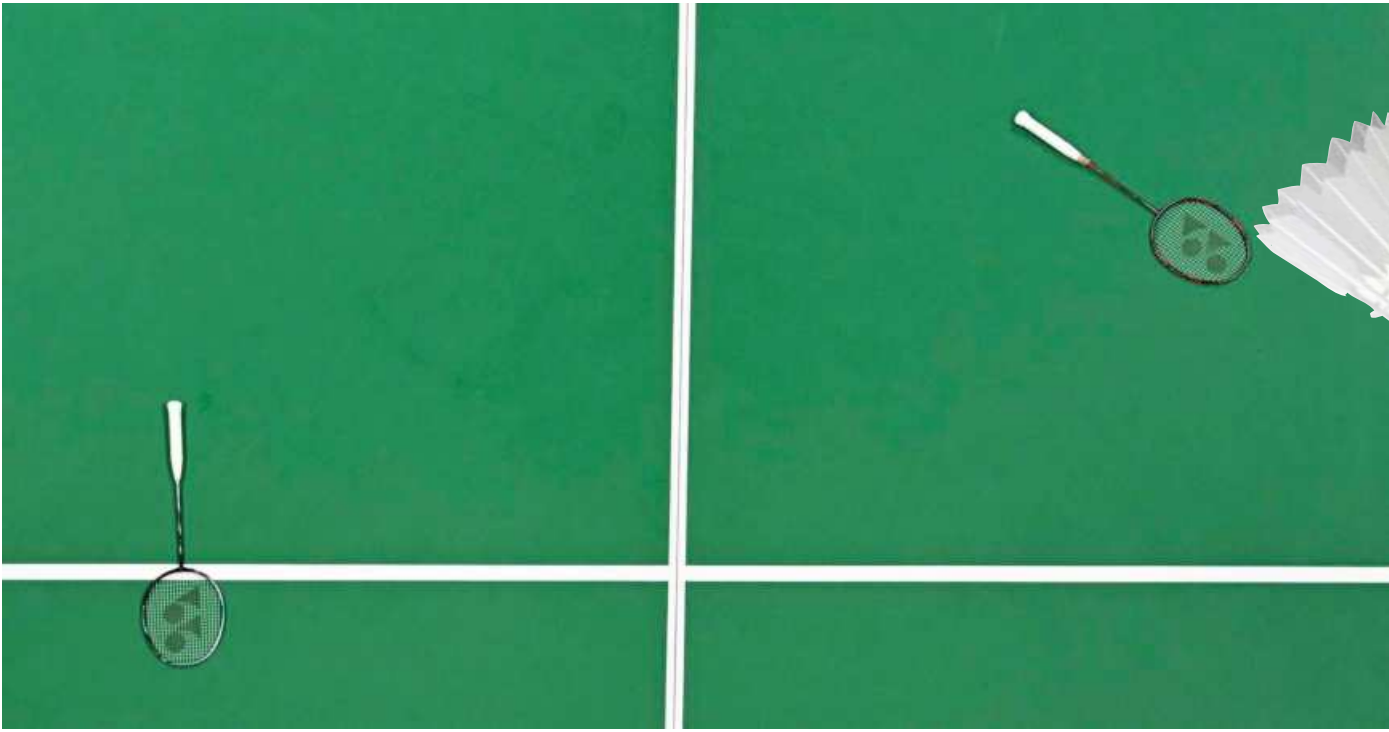
▼ The new format is not merely a technical adjustment. It is a shift in the very grammar of badminton

▼ For a sport increasingly conscious of broadcast windows and audience retention, the logic is understandable

▼ The 3x21 system allows time for strategies to emerge, for weaknesses to be exposed, and for players to respond

Our responsibility is to ensure badminton continues to grow, inspire, and thrive at every level. After extensive testing and consultation, we believe the 3x15 system provides a strong foundation for the sport's future

LEESWADTRAKUL
BWF president



How proteins are being tweaked to be quantum sensors inside the body

Most existing quantum sensors are made from solid materials such as diamond, which are difficult to place inside cells; however, cells can produce proteins naturally, with the correct genetic instructions, and they can also be fused to other proteins, allowing researchers to position them at precise locations inside a body

Manjeera Gowravaram

For decades, fluorescent proteins have been among the most powerful tools in biology. They glow when illuminated, allowing scientists to see where molecules are inside cells and how they move. From tracking cancer cells to mapping neural circuits, these luminous markers transformed the life sciences, work recognised with a Nobel Prize in 2008.

Now, two major studies published in *Nature* suggest that fluorescent proteins can do more than glow. Certain fluorescent proteins can be modified to detect magnetic fields and radio waves from inside living cells. In effect they behave as quantum sensors, devices whose operation depends on the behaviour of electrons at the smallest scales.

Until recently, quantum technologies were confined to ultra-cold laboratories filled with specialised equipment. Biology by contrast has been viewed as an unlikely home for quantum effects. Living cells are warm, crowded, and constantly in motion – conditions thought to destroy fragile quantum states.

The new results challenge that assumption, opening a path towards genetically encoded quantum sensors and a new class of hybrid quantum-biological technologies.

Hidden sensitivity

When a fluorescent protein absorbs light, one of its electrons is pushed into a higher-energy state. Usually, the electron quickly returns to its original state and releases energy as light. That simple process is what makes the protein glow.

In some proteins, however, this journey is more complicated. The excited electron can briefly interact with a nearby molecule inside the protein, forming what scientists call a radical pair, two molecules that each carry an unpaired electron.

For a short time, the spins of these electrons are linked. The outcome of their interaction depends on weak magnetic influences around them. Even weak magnetic fields can change how the pair behaves, which in turn alters how much light the protein emits.

Chemists have known about this effect for decades, and it has been proposed as a possible explanation for how some animals sense Earth's magnetic field. What had been missing was a way to reliably harness this phenomenon inside living cells.

Protein sensors

Researchers at the University of Chicago's

Pritzker School of Molecular Engineering focused on a variant of enhanced yellow fluorescent protein (EYFP), a close relative of green fluorescent protein. They discovered that EYFP possesses a metastable triplet state – a temporary electronic configuration in which an electron's magnetic spin can be isolated and controlled.

Using carefully timed laser pulses, the team initialised the spin state of EYFP, manipulated it with microwave fields, and read it out optically, completing the full sequence required of a qubit.

They also detected optically driven magnetic resonance signals from EYFP inside living cells. These effects appeared in human kidney cells at low temperature and in *Escherichia coli* bacteria even at room temperature, showing that the protein's quantum behaviour survives in biology's noisy environment.

A second research group at the University of Oxford took a different approach. Working with a plant light-sensing protein, they used genetic engineering to create a family of magneto-sensitive fluorescent proteins called MagLOV. Through repeated rounds of mutation and selection, they produced versions with stronger and more stable magnetic responses.

The researchers showed that MagLOV

The studies demonstrate that proteins can be programmed through DNA to act as quantum sensors and point to a future in which these sensors reshape how scientists probe living systems enabling nanoscale measurements

proteins exhibit optically detected magnetic resonance in living bacterial cells at room temperature. In other words, radio waves at specific frequencies can predictably change fluorescence, directly revealing electron-spin behaviour.

Historically, biological candidates for quantum sensors were limited to purified, in-vitro systems, showed weak responses, or degraded quickly under light exposure. The engineered MagLOV proteins overcome many of these obstacles by combining stability, sensitivity, and genetic compatibility.

Together, the studies demonstrate that proteins can be programmed through DNA to act as quantum sensors.

Why inside cells matters

Most existing quantum sensors are made from solid materials such as diamond. These devices can be extraordinarily sensitive, but they are difficult to place inside cells or attach to specific biological targets.

An illustration of the AsLOV 2 protein, which scientists used to engineer the MagLOV protein. NATURE 649, 1172–1179 (2026)

Protein sensors are fundamentally different. Cells can produce them naturally once given the correct genetic instructions. The sensors can also be fused to other proteins, allowing researchers to position them at precise locations inside the cell.

This matters because many crucial biological processes involve subtle magnetic or electronic effects, including enzyme reactions with metal atoms, formation of short-lived free radicals, and electron transfer during respiration and photosynthesis.

Until now, studying these phenomena inside living cells has been nearly impossible. Protein-based quantum sensors offer a potential solution.

More than detection

The MagLOV researchers also showed that magnetic modulation can improve conventional fluorescence imaging. By switching a magnetic field on and off, they separated the MagLOV signal from background fluorescence and cellular autofluorescence. This technique, known as lock-in detection, enhances weak signals in noisy environments.

They further demonstrated a form of spatial localization based on magnetic resonance. Using magnetic-field gradients, they could determine the position of MagLOV-expressing cells within a three-dimensional sample, even when light scattering would normally blur the image.

The approach resembles some principles of magnetic resonance imaging (MRI), but uses genetically encoded fluorescent proteins as the signal source.

New ways of seeing

These studies point to a future in which genetically encodable quantum sensors reshape how scientists probe living systems. As sensitivities improve, protein-based qubits and magnetic-resonance probes could enable nanoscale measurements of magnetic fields, electric fields, temperature, and chemical environments directly inside cells.

Such sensors might track protein shape changes, monitor biochemical reactions in real time, or reveal how drugs bind to their targets with unprecedented precision.

Important challenges remain, though. Protein-based quantum sensors are currently less sensitive than solid-state devices, coherence times are shorter, and photobleaching remains a concern. Yet fluorescent proteins themselves took decades to become routine tools, and similar improvement could steadily close the gap.

(Manjeera Gowravaram has a Ph.D. in RNA biochemistry and works as a freelance science writer. gmanjeera@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Two major studies published in *Nature* suggest that fluorescent proteins can detect magnetic fields and radio waves from inside living cells. In effect they behave as quantum sensors

The new results open a path towards genetically encoded quantum sensors and a new class of hybrid quantum-biological technologies

Scientists found that engineered proteins could be sensors in *Escherichia coli* bacteria even at room temperature, showing that their quantum behaviour could survive a noisy environment

Such sensors might track protein shape changes, monitor biochemical reactions in real time, or reveal how drugs bind to their targets with unprecedented precision

BIG SHOT



A closeup of a small section of the Helix Nebula, an expanding shell of gas and dust, by the James Webb Space Telescope. Winds of hot gas stream upwards from the bottom, like thin liquid blown up a sheet of glass.NASA, ESA, CSA, STSCI

QUESTION CORNER

Smoke vortex



Q: Why does wildfire smoke swirl only one way in the air?

A: Sometimes wildfire smoke in the stratosphere collects into a compact bubble of smoke that spins in a coherent vortex, clockwise in the northern hemisphere and counter-clockwise in the southern hemisphere.

Two new studies, published in *Weather and Climate Dynamics* and presented at a recent meeting of the American Meteorological Society, have found why. The smoke particles absorb sunlight and warm the air around them. That makes the air buoyant, and it rises through the smoky core, pushing the clump of smoke particles up over time.

Earth's atmosphere is rotating and has many layers. If you warmed one patch of stratospheric air and kept the warming at the same height, the air just above will start swirling one way and the air just below, the other way.

Because the smoke particles are rising, the heating pattern also moves up with the smoke. This matters because the atmosphere's 'push' to make the air rotate also moves upwards. As the warm core passes through a layer, it will briefly nudge the air into rotating one way. Once it has moved on, the later push in that same layer will undo much of the earlier



Wildfire smoke in the northeast Pacific Ocean, September 2020. NASA

change. As a result the most coherent rotation is wrapped around the smoke bubble itself, like a collar that travels upwards with it.

The rotating bubble also acts like a container, keeping the warmer smoke concentrated near its centre, rather than mixing with the surroundings, and allowing it to keep rising.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

The record high cargo handled by the Vizag port in 327 days

80 million tonnes. This marks the Vishakapatnam port's fastest achievement in its 92-year history. VPA Chairperson M. Angamuthu said the port crossed the 80-million-tonne mark on February 21, setting a new benchmark in operational performance. PTI

Power investments in Bihar, Jharkhand reviewed by Adani

40,000 in ₹ crore. Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani visited sites in Jharkhand and Bihar, reviewing major power investments to the tune of over ₹40,000 crore, which underscore the company's presence in eastern India. PTI

Illegal properties to be demolished in anti-encroachment drive

1,489 The Rajkot Municipal Corporation, with the support of the police, will tear down 1,489 properties along the banks of the Aji River and on a municipal town planning road in Jangleshwar, Municipal Commissioner Tushar Sumera said. PTI

The estimated Indian tourist footfall to Israel by 2027

69,000 Israel, which saw a double crisis of COVID-19 and the war, is expecting to recover and reach the 2019 level of around 69,000 visitors from India by 2027, a senior representative of the Israel Ministry of Tourism said. PTI

Magnitude of the earthquake that hit Nepal's Koshi province

4.1 A mild tremor was felt in Nepal's Koshi province on Sunday morning. The earthquake was recorded with its epicentre located at Ritak area of Sankhuwasabha district at 7:31 am. There was no immediate report of any damage. PTI

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Why are apple traders in J&K worried?

Why are apple producers concerned about the trade deals with the U.S. and the EU? Why are countries in the West able to produce a better yield of apples? What about controlled-atmosphere cold storage prices? Why are party leaders urging the Union government to re-evaluate the deal?

EXPLAINER

Peerzada Ashiq

The story so far:

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah and Leader of the Opposition in J&K Mehbooba Mufti have termed the India-U.S. trade deal as a death knell for the horticulture sector, especially for apple production in Kashmir. The criticism has grown shriller in the backdrop of India's decision to reduce basic customs duty on apples imported from the U.S. from 50% to 25%, even though the Minimum Import Price (MIP) was set at ₹80 per kilogram. Under the new India-European Union trade deal, import duty on fresh fruits was reduced to 20% under a Tariff Rate Quota (TRQ) system. Only 50,000 tonnes per year of apples will be allowed from the EU at this reduced duty, to avoid the sudden flooding of Indian markets. However, the deal agrees to increase the quota to 1,00,000 tonnes over the next 10 years.

How important is apple production?

According to the J&K Economic Survey 2025-26, apple production comprises 50% of the total horticulture production of J&K against pear, apricot, peach, plum, cherry, citrus, mango, walnut, almond etc. The horticulture sector produces roughly ₹10,000 crore in revenue and employs about 35 lakh individuals, either directly or indirectly, thereby supporting approximately seven lakh families, the official survey suggested.

In 2024, apple production in J&K stood at 21 lakh metric tonnes. Over 173.07 lakh hectares of land in J&K are under apple orchards. J&K contributes to over 70% of the total apple production in the country.

The apple is the fourth most important fruit crop in India.

Besides J&K, Tamil Nadu, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Nagaland, and Sikkim also produce apples.



Precarious trade: Workers separating rotten apples in Pulwama, Srinagar in 2025. IMRAN NISSAR

Why are there fears?

Kashmir cannot compete with apples produced in Western countries due to their farming practices, favourable government policy and technological intervention. One estimate suggests that orchardists in New Zealand, the U.S., and in the EU on an average operate on 50-plus hectare farms against an average of 0.40 hectares in J&K. Only 7-8 tonnes of apples per hectare can be produced in India, whereas 40-70 tonnes per hectare are produced in countries like the U.S., Iran, New Zealand and China owing to better geography, advanced technology and mechanisation, says Nasir Hamid Khan, former vice-president of the Kashmir Chamber of Commerce and Industries (KCCI), a pan-Valley traders body. Moreover, Western countries have already introduced AI system technologies for pruning, pollination,

harvesting, infield-sorting and bagging.

How will it impact off-season pricing?

Nations in the West have also mastered many popular varieties of apples such as gala apples. India introduced the gala variety only very recently and it is yet to reach its optimum production quality in terms of colour, taste, juice, shape as well as yield. Orchardists in Kashmir fear apples from the West will enter India at cheaper prices and in turn hit controlled-atmosphere cold storage prices the most. With reduced import duty, fresh New Zealand apples will enter Indian markets at cheaper prices, directly undercutting Indian apples stored in cold facilities, says Izhan Javed, a senior member of the J&K Fruits and Vegetables Processing and Integrated Cold Chain Association. Kashmir stores 397.08 lakh metric tonnes of apples in 92 cold

storages currently. Local orchardists in Kashmir have invested heavily in cold storage infrastructure. "The trade deals threaten to make these investments economically unviable, endangering the entire post-harvest ecosystem built with public and private capital. The trade deal has the potential to destroy off-season price stability and push farmers back into distress sales," warns Mr. Javed.

What are J&K parties demanding?

J&K parties and traders are urging the Centre to relook the deal and ensure safeguards for apple producers. In J&K, parties are clamouring for a joint strategy to pressure the Centre to exclude apples from the deal. The Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) leader and legislator Waheed-ur-Rehmaan Parra has sought an all-party meeting "to devise a collective strategy". "Out of 30 lakh kanals of orchard land, only 30,000 kanals are under high-density cultivation. There is a need to have interest-free loans for farmers under Holistic Agriculture Development Programme (HADP) to compete globally," says Mr. Parra.

The PDP also pitched for the expansion of cold storage and controlled-atmosphere storage infrastructure "to prevent distress sales". It demanded the activation of dry port projects in J&K for the smooth ferrying of apples from the Valley to the markets outside.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has also echoed these concerns. He said the trade deal will "spell disaster for the horticulture sector if left unaddressed". Mr. Abdullah says time has come to invest in improving productivity and quality before the market is flooded by cheaper apples. We don't know what the benefits will be in the rest of the country, but we are seeing a loss, Mr. Abdullah warned. He underlined that the deals have paved an "uneven playing field for local orchardists and better-quality imports will dominate the market and the local produce will get devalued".

THE GIST

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Why did the U.S. drop a core radiation safety rule?

What is the ALARA principle? What has the U.S. Department of Energy said?

K.S. Parthasarathy

The story so far:

The Linear No-Threshold (LNT) model and the ALARA principle have served as the conceptual and operational foundations of the global radiation protection framework for many decades. But, on January 12, the U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) "eliminated" ALARA from its directives and regulations, departing significantly from longstanding national and international practices.

What is the LNT model?

The LNT model is a risk estimation framework that says any amount of ionising radiation, no matter how small, carries some risk of causing harm, especially cancer. In other words, there is no threshold below which radiation is considered completely risk-free. And the risk increases linearly with dose. ALARA, short for "as low as reasonably

achievable", is the operational philosophy of radiation protection. 'Reasonably' is the most important condition. The philosophy balances safety with feasibility, cost, and societal need, and its aim is to improve continuously, including better shielding, administrative procedures, and training. Thus, in practice ALARA aims to reduce unnecessary exposure using engineering controls and encourages a safety culture. Unfortunately, when these principles are misapplied, as they have often been, they create a baggage of woes. The International Commission on Radiological Protection (ICRP) and other stakeholders are realising that modern radiological protection requires a different approach.

Why has the U.S. eliminated ALARA?

"The DOE's decades of nuclear facility operating experience confirms that DOE's mission to foster nuclear innovation and advanced nuclear technologies could be met more effectively if the current

radiation framework were reformed," a Department memorandum said in a follow-up to U.S. President Donald Trump's orders. Critics have argued that the shift appears politically motivated and relies on non peer-reviewed internal reports, and risks undermining worker protection, public trust, and regulatory coherence. Indeed, the U.S. is now at odds with international bodies such as the ICRP, the UN Scientific Committee on the Effects of Atomic Radiation, the World Health Organization, etc. all of which continue to rely on LNT as a basis for radiation protection. No large-scale, high-quality epidemiological or mechanistic evidence has emerged to justify replacing LNT with alternative dose-response models, including hormesis (which says low dose radiation is okay). While hormesis remains biologically plausible, its variability across populations, ethical limitations, and lack of reproducible human data render it unsuitable for regulatory use.

What lies ahead?

The ICRP hasn't shown any indication that the dose limits will be revised. There may be a renewed effort to accept a low dose level below which no regulation is required. However, critics have emphasised the importance of public perception. Even if some experts believe higher dose thresholds could be justified scientifically, the optics of abandoning ALARA and LNT are problematic. For those living near nuclear facilities, the change may look like a lowering of safety standards rather than a refinement of scientific assumptions. Without broad scientific consensus, transparent communication, and meaningful public engagement, critics fear that the policy shift will deepen mistrust, and fuel opposition to nuclear projects and existing and future facilities.

Possible evidence of cancer and non-cancer effects at low doses have also appeared in more recent studies, such as the ongoing 'Million Person Study'. Another study of nearly a million young individuals revealed that a few of them may suffer blood related cancers at very low doses (*Nature Medicine*, 2023). One expects the ICRP will take note of such work.

India has been at the forefront of complying with internationally accepted radiation protection practices and must continue to do so.

K.S. Parthasarathy is former secretary, Atomic Energy Regulatory Board.

THE GIST

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